

COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Transparency, RTI and Information Sharing - Complete Topic Package

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Transparency, RTI and Information Sharing

TEN-SESSION CORE PATH • PRACTICE • OPTIONAL ADVANCED • REGISTER NOTES

1 Transparency, disclosure, information sharing, accountability and privacy

2 RTI foundations: rights-holder, public authority and existing records

3 Proactive disclosure, record management, open data and usable information

4 Request route: application, transfer, time limits, fees and assistance

5 Exemptions, harm, public-interest balancing and the twenty-year rule

6 Severability and third-party consultation without a disclosure veto

7 Appeals, burden of proof, remedies, penalties and excluded organisations

8 Information Commission independence and the RTI Amendment Act, 2019

9 Official secrecy, Puttaswamy privacy and the DPDP-RTI interface

10 Digital information sharing, PYQ routes and answer architecture

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / SESSION INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Transparency, RTI and Information Sharing - Complete Topic Package	4
CURRENT-AFFAIRS ANCHOR	4
BASIC LEARNING SESSION	5
SESSION 1 - Transparency, disclosure, information sharing, accountability and privacy	5
SESSION 2 - RTI foundations: rights-holder, public authority and existing records	6
SESSION 3 - Proactive disclosure, record management, open data and usable information	6
SESSION 4 - Request route: application, transfer, time limits, fees and assistance	7
SESSION 5 - Exemptions, harm, public-interest balancing and the twenty-year rule	8
SESSION 6 - Severability and third-party consultation without a disclosure veto	9
SESSION 7 - Appeals, burden of proof, remedies, penalties and excluded organisations	9
SESSION 8 - Information Commission independence and the RTI Amendment Act, 2019	10
SESSION 9 - Official secrecy, Puttaswamy privacy and the DPDP-RTI interface	10
SESSION 10 - Digital information sharing, PYQ routes and answer architecture	11
BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION	12
PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE	36
ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS	41
OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER	44
1. Transparency as an information architecture of power	44
2. From proactive disclosure to information stewardship	45
3. Exemption reasoning: class, harm, balance and narrowness	45
4. Severability, mosaic risk and calibrated access	46
5. Third-party procedure and multi-party fairness	47
6. Enforcement quality and institutional independence	47
7. Official Secrets Act: conflict of norms and administrative culture	48
8. Privacy after Puttaswamy and the changed Section 8(1)(j)	48
9. Information sharing, interoperability and open-government limits	49
10. Advanced answer synthesis, reforms and source boundaries	49
CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES	50

EMBEDDED TWELVE-PANEL ASCII REVISION ATLAS 50

ONE-PAGE CONCEPT GRID 57

CORE REVISION SPINE 58

SOURCE AND ATTRIBUTION DISCIPLINE 58

ANSWER SPINE 59

Transparency, RTI and Information Sharing - Complete Topic Package

Subject: Ethics **Section:** Subject-wide Syllabus **Generation:** learner-v2:g1 **Ownership:** GS-IV Ethics topic; recent official-paper questions retain their exact year, paper and source note. **Source policy:** complete Basic owner first; solved practice before optional Advanced depth; consolidated register notes last.

CURRENT-AFFAIRS ANCHOR

RTI propagation in 2025-26 and the commenced DPDP amendment to RTI

- **FACT:** Fact: DoPT's 17 April 2025 annual-programme guidelines invited State Information Commissions and Administrative Training Institutes to submit 2025-26 proposals for propagation of the RTI Act to improve transparency and accountability.
- **FACT:** Fact: The official programme document links RTI propagation with training, awareness and effective implementation rather than treating enactment alone as sufficient.
- **FACT:** Fact: MeitY notification G.S.R. 843(E), published on 13 November 2025, commenced DPDP Act Section 44(3) on the date of publication.
- **FACT:** Fact: Section 44(3) substitutes RTI Act Section 8(1)(j) with the words 'information which relates to personal information'.
- **FACT:** Fact: The notification places Section 6(9) and Section 27(1)(d) in the one-year tranche commencing 13 November 2026.
- **FACT:** Fact: Its eighteen-month tranche, commencing 13 May 2027, includes Sections 3 to 5, the rest of Section 6, Sections 7 to 17 and linked core architecture.

ANALYSIS: Inference / administrative link: The two sources show the contemporary double task: build practical RTI capacity and proactive openness while updating privacy-transparency decisions to the amended statutory text and the DPDP framework's phased commencement.

ANALYSIS: Limit: The 2025-26 programme document is an implementation and grant guideline, not evidence that every authority complies with Section 4. G.S.R. 843(E) does not make the whole DPDP Act operational on 13 November 2025; as at 29 August 2026, the eighteen-month tranche is still prospective.

Official source links:

- https://rti.dopt.gov.in/Writereaddata/Guidelines_2025_26.pdf
- <https://www.meity.gov.in/static/uploads/2025/11/c56ceae6c383460ca69577428d36828b.pdf>

Source caution: The corrected canonical Topic 15 Basic and Advanced owners control the teaching sequence. Transparency is systemic visibility; disclosure is a particular release; information sharing is purpose-bound exchange; open data concerns reusable datasets; accountability requires an actor, standard, competent forum, judgment and correction or consequence; privacy protects dignity, autonomy and contextual control. Do not use these terms as synonyms. RTI covers existing information held or controlled by a public authority, including private-body information accessible under another law; it does not generally compel creation of opinions or analysis. Section 4 proactive disclosure should be current, intelligible and accessible. Section 6 applicants need not give reasons; Section 7 ordinarily uses thirty days and forty-eight hours for life or liberty. Section 8 exemptions require clause-linked reasoning; Section 8(2) retains public-interest balancing; Section 10 requires reasonable severability; Section 11 consultation is not a third-party veto. Section 19 places the denial burden on the PIO. Section 20 penalty is personal, hearing-based, conditional on specified failure and capped at twenty-five thousand rupees; it is not an automatic departmental fine. Section 24 exclusions retain corruption and human-rights exceptions, with Commission approval and a forty-five-day rule for the latter. The Official Secrets Act, 1923 remains in force; the Second ARC recommendation to repeal and relocate genuine secrecy offences was not enacted. RTI Section 22 overrides inconsistent law but does not abolish legitimate RTI exemptions. The RTI Amendment Act, 2019 shifted tenure and remuneration detail for Central and State Information Commissioners from the Act to Central rules; the three-year term comes from the 2019 Rules, not the Amendment's text. Describe the resulting independence issue as a structural concern, not proof of actual interference or abolition of the right. Puttaswamy is the constitutional privacy foundation. DPDP Act Section 44(3) commenced on 13 November 2025 and substituted RTI Section 8(1)(j) with 'information

which relates to personal information'. Sections 8(2), 10 and 11 remain, but do not claim without authority that Section 8(2) automatically recreates every deleted qualifier. G.S.R. 843(E) phased commencement: as at 29 August 2026 the Act is not wholly operational; Section 6(9) and Section 27(1)(d) commence on 13 November 2026, while the major eighteen-month tranche begins 13 May 2027. Official local GS-IV PDFs control PYQ text. Cross-routed questions retain their primary owners, and full case-study method remains Topic 22-owned.

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

SESSION 1 - Transparency, disclosure, information sharing, accountability and privacy

Subject: Ethics | **Tier:** Basic/Core | **GS Paper:** GS-IV **Scope:** Transparency and information sharing in government; Right to Information; codes of ethics; citizen-facing accountability. Full case-study method remains Topic 22-owned.
Source base: Right to Information Act, 2005 as amended; RTI (Amendment) Act, 2019; RTI service-condition Rules, 2019; Official Secrets Act, 1923; *K.S. Puttaswamy* (2017); Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 and G.S.R. 843(E), 13 November 2025; Second ARC First and Fourth Reports; locally held official UPSC GS-IV papers. **FACT:** = sourced fact | **ANALYSIS:** = analysis/inference | **CURRENT:** = verified current position.

1. Transparency, disclosure, information sharing, accountability and privacy

PUBLIC POWER

```

|
+--> TRANSPARENCY = continuing visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records, results
|
|       |
|       +--> DISCLOSURE = a particular release, proactive or on request
|       +--> OPEN DATA = reusable public datasets, commonly machine-readable
|
+--> INFORMATION SHARING = authorised exchange for a defined function
      (may remain restricted; not necessarily public)
|
+--> ACCOUNTABILITY = actor + standard + forum + answer + judgment + remedy/consequence
|
+--> PRIVACY = dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information
  
```

FACT: These concepts overlap but are not synonyms:

Concept	Precise exam meaning	What it is not
Transparency	An institutional condition in which the exercise of public power is visible to appropriate scrutiny.	One exceptional or compelled release.
Disclosure	Release of specified information to an applicant or the public.	A complete accountability system.
Information sharing	Purpose-bound movement of information among authorised actors.	Automatic public publication or unrestricted circulation inside government.
Open data	Data made available for reuse, normally with machine-readable format and metadata.	A substitute for reasons, correspondence, files or appeal.
Accountability	An identified actor answers against a standard before a competent forum that can judge and correct.	A dashboard that nobody must explain.
Privacy	Protection of dignity, autonomy and appropriate control over personal information across contexts.	A blanket shield for every record connected with a public servant.

ANALYSIS: Causal chain: information reduces asymmetry; visibility permits verification; verification supports answerability; a competent forum converts answerability into correction or consequence. The chain can break at every stage. A data dump may be visible but unintelligible; an exposé may reveal wrongdoing but produce no remedy.

UPSC line: Transparency enables accountability, but only a forum with corrective capacity completes it.

SESSION 2 - RTI foundations: rights-holder, public authority and existing records

2. RTI foundations: rights-holder, public authority and existing records

FACT: **Section 3** confers the right to information on citizens. The applicant ordinarily does not have to prove a personal stake or special injury.

FACT: The Section 2 architecture matters:

- **Information** covers material in any form: records, documents, memos, e-mails, opinions already recorded, advice already recorded, press releases, circulars, orders, logbooks, contracts, reports, papers, samples, models and electronic data. It also includes information relating to a private body that a public authority can access under another law.

- **Right to information** includes inspection of work/documents/records, taking notes or certified extracts, certified copies, certified samples and access in electronic modes recognised by the Act.

- **Record** is medium-neutral. Digitisation changes storage, not the basic access principle.

- **Public authority** is determined by the Act's constitutional, statutory, notification/control and substantial-financing routes. ANALYSIS: Do not write that every private entity receiving any public money is automatically covered.

FACT: **Existing-record boundary:** a PIO supplies information held or controlled; the Act does not generally require creation of a new forecast, legal opinion, explanation or research product. If the reason for a decision already exists on file, it is information; if no reason was recorded, RTI cannot manufacture one, though the absence itself may reveal an accountability failure.

Ethical importance

ANALYSIS: RTI changes the citizen from a supplicant asking for official favour into a rights-holder using a statutory route. It also changes the burden of governance: the applicant need not justify curiosity, while the State must link withholding to law.

India-centric example: a citizen can seek existing inspection reports, sanction orders and recorded movement of a delayed land-mutation file. The PIO need not answer an abstract question such as "Why is governance inefficient?" unless a recorded document contains that analysis.

SESSION 3 - Proactive disclosure, record management, open data and usable information

3. Proactive disclosure, record management, open data and usable information

FACT: **Section 4(1)(a)** requires public authorities to maintain records duly catalogued and indexed in a manner that facilitates RTI, to computerise appropriate records within reasonable time and subject to resources, and to connect systems through networks where access is facilitated.

FACT: **Section 4(1)(b)** provides a detailed proactive-publication architecture. High-yield categories include organisation and functions; powers and duties; decision procedure and supervision channels; norms; rules and manuals; document categories; consultation arrangements; boards and committees; directory and remuneration; budget and expenditure; subsidy programmes and beneficiaries; concessions/permits; electronic information; citizen facilities; and PIO particulars.

FACT: **Section 4(2)** requires a constant endeavour to provide as much information suo motu at regular intervals through communication methods so that the public has minimum resort to individual RTI applications.

GOOD SECTION 4 CYCLE

create reliable record

- > catalogue/index
- > review privacy/security
- > publish useful core information
- > add metadata and update date
- > provide accessible/searchable formats
- > receive correction feedback
- > update and archive

ANALYSIS: Publication quality is ethical substance:

- **Current:** obsolete budget and PIO lists mislead.
- **Findable:** buried files or broken links impose a hidden access cost.
- **Intelligible:** unexplained codes can preserve information asymmetry.
- **Accessible:** local-language and disability access affect equal citizenship.
- **Reusable:** machine-readable data supports analysis, but a PDF may still be appropriate for a speaking order.
- **Safe:** aggregation, masking and suppression may protect personal or security-sensitive details.

Open-data boundary: a city may publish anonymised transport data for reuse while retaining RTI access to recorded route-change reasons. Open data and RTI complement each other.

Trap: "Uploaded" does not necessarily mean transparent. Unsearchable scanned dumps can be compliance theatre.

SESSION 4 - Request route: application, transfer, time limits, fees and assistance

4. Request route: application, transfer, time limits, fees and assistance

FACT: **Section 5** establishes Central/State Public Information Officers and assistants as the operational access points.

FACT: **Section 6 essentials:**

1. A request may be written or electronic.
2. It may use English, Hindi or the official language of the area.
3. It should specify the information sought.
4. The applicant need not give reasons or unnecessary personal details.
5. Where a person cannot make a written request, reasonable assistance must reduce it to writing.
6. Under **Section 6(3)**, a request concerning another public authority, or whose subject is more closely connected with it, is transferred as soon as practicable and within five days; the applicant is informed.

FACT: **Section 7 timeline and access protections:**

Situation	Rule
Ordinary request	Decision as expeditiously as possible and within 30 days .
Life or liberty	Information within 48 hours where the nexus is established.
No decision in time	Deemed refusal , enabling appeal.
Delayed beyond statutory period	Information supplied free of charge under Section 7(6).
Below-poverty-line applicant	Fee protection applies under the statutory proviso/rules.
Sensory disability	Assistance must enable access to the record.
Rejection	Communicate reasons, appeal period and appellate authority.

ANALYSIS: Life or liberty is an urgent exception, not a label for every important request. A strong answer shows the connection between information delay and threatened life or liberty.

Administrative ethic: simple filing, assistance and predictable time limits counter procedural domination. A technically available right becomes unequal when only legally skilled citizens can use it.

SESSION 5 - Exemptions, harm, public-interest balancing and the twenty-year rule

5. Exemptions, harm, public-interest balancing and the twenty-year rule

FACT: RTI is disclosure-oriented, not absolute. **Section 8(1)** protects specified interests. The exam method is not to memorise labels alone but to connect the clause, interest and likely harm.

Exemption family	Protected interest / caution
Sovereignty, integrity, security, strategic/scientific/economic interests, foreign relations, incitement	Genuine national interests; avoid turning “security” into an unreviewed slogan.
Court-forbidden information / contempt	Respect for judicial restriction.
Legislative privilege	Institutional privilege.
Commercial confidence, trade secrets, intellectual property	Competitive interest, subject to the Act's public-interest architecture.
Fiduciary relationship	Protected confidence; “fiduciary” must fit the relationship, not merely official possession.
Foreign-government confidence	International confidence.
Safety or confidential source	Life, physical safety and source protection.
Investigation/apprehension/prosecution	The test concerns actual impediment, not the bare fact that an investigation exists.
Cabinet papers	Protect deliberation within the statutory conditions; decisions and reasons have their own proviso structure.
Personal information	Use the current post-13 November 2025 statutory text discussed in Section 9.

FACT: **Section 8(2)** permits access notwithstanding the Official Secrets Act or Section 8(1) exemptions if public interest in disclosure outweighs harm to protected interests.

BALANCING TEST

exact clause

- > protected interest
- > concrete and likely harm
- > specific public benefit of disclosure
- > can redaction/aggregation reduce harm?
- > reasoned decision + appeal

FACT: **Section 8(3)** creates a twenty-year disclosure rule subject to continuing statutory exceptions. It is not a universal automatic declassification rule; the Act preserves specified clauses beyond the period and provides a Central Government determination route for disputes about the originating date.

ANALYSIS: Public interest is not whatever attracts curiosity. Relevant considerations include exposure of corruption, health/safety, public expenditure, environmental harm, rights violation and integrity of a public decision. Countervailing harm must also be concrete.

SESSION 6 - Severability and third-party consultation without a disclosure veto

6. Severability and third-party consultation without a disclosure veto

FACT: **Section 10 - severability:** if exempt information is reasonably separable from the remainder, access must be given to the non-exempt part. The notice communicates the decision, reasons and material findings, decision-maker, fees and review rights.

100-page inspection report

```
|
+--> 3 pages reveal protected source / personal identifiers -> redact or withhold
|
+--> 97 pages contain findings, expenditure and remedial action -> disclose
```

ANALYSIS: Blanket denial is unethical where narrower protection works. Conversely, impossible redaction need not be pretended merely to release an unintelligible residue; the authority should explain why.

FACT: **Section 11 - third-party information:** where information relates to or was supplied by a third party and treated as confidential, the PIO gives written notice, invites representation and then makes the statutory decision. High-yield timing:

- notice to third party within **five days** of receiving the request;
- representation opportunity within **ten days** of notice;
- decision within **forty days** of the request in the Section 11 route;
- decision notice informs the third party of appeal rights.

FACT: Trade or commercial secrets protected by law receive the statutory treatment, while public interest remains relevant under the Act.

Trap: Section 11 creates consultation, not consent. A contractor cannot veto disclosure merely by objecting; equally, the PIO should not ignore legitimate confidential interests.

SESSION 7 - Appeals, burden of proof, remedies, penalties and excluded organisations

7. Appeals, burden of proof, remedies, penalties and excluded organisations

FACT: **Section 19 appeal ladder:**

PIO decision / deemed refusal

- > FIRST APPEAL within public authority (ordinarily 30 days)
- > decision ordinarily 30 days; up to 45 with written reasons
- > SECOND APPEAL to CIC/SIC (ordinarily 90 days)

Delay may be condoned for sufficient cause. Under **Section 19(5)**, the burden of proving that denial was justified lies on the PIO who denied the request. Commission decisions are binding within the Act. The Commission can require steps necessary to secure compliance, including access, appointment of a PIO, publication, record-management changes, training and annual-report action as statutorily relevant, and can address loss or detriment through the Act's remedial powers.

FACT: **Section 20 penalty:** after giving a reasonable opportunity of being heard, the Commission may impose **Rs 250 per day**, capped at **Rs 25,000**, for specified conduct such as refusal without reasonable cause, delay, malafide denial, knowingly incorrect/incomplete/misleading information, destruction or obstruction. The PIO must show reasonable and diligent conduct. Persistent or malafide failure may lead to a disciplinary recommendation under applicable service rules.

ANALYSIS: Penalty is neither automatic for every delay nor a fine mechanically imposed on the department. Distinguish access remedy, compensation, personal penalty and disciplinary recommendation.

FACT: **Section 24:** notified intelligence and security organisations are generally outside the Act, but information concerning allegations of **corruption** or **human-rights violations** is not absolutely excluded. Human-rights

information requires Information Commission approval and is supplied within **45 days**, notwithstanding the ordinary Section 7 period. State Governments have a parallel notification architecture.

Trap: "Security organisation" does not mean "no RTI under any circumstances."

SESSION 8 - Information Commission independence and the RTI Amendment Act, 2019

8. Information Commission independence and the RTI Amendment Act, 2019

FACT: Before the 2019 amendment, the Act itself fixed central and state commissioner tenure and linked remuneration to specified constitutional/senior offices. The original design used a five-year tenure subject to age sixty-five and differentiated rules for Chief and other Commissioners.

FACT: The **RTI (Amendment) Act, 2019** changed Sections 13 and 16 so that tenure, salaries, allowances and other service conditions of the CIC/ICs and State CIC/SICs are prescribed by the **Central Government**. Section 27 rule-making authority was correspondingly expanded.

FACT: The **2019 Rules**, rather than the Amendment Act's text, prescribe a **three-year** term, subject to the age ceiling.

Balanced assessment	Content
ANALYSIS: Independence concern	A watchdog adjudicating claims against government benefits from tenure and remuneration insulated from the executive it reviews. Moving core detail from statute to rules may weaken durability or appearance of independence.
ANALYSIS: Federal concern	Central prescription also covers State Information Commissions.
Counter-position	Uniform conditions and executive flexibility may be defended as administrative rationalisation.
Essential caution	The change does not prove actual interference, abolish RTI rights or remove the appeal/penalty architecture.

ANALYSIS: Independence also depends on transparent merit-based appointment, timely filling of vacancies, resources, staff, quality of orders and freedom from performance pressure. Tenure is important but not the sole variable.

UPSC conclusion: The 2019 change raises a legitimate institutional-design concern; state it as a risk to insulation, not as a finding of proven misconduct.

SESSION 9 - Official secrecy, Puttaswamy privacy and the DPDP-RTI interface

9. Official secrecy, Puttaswamy privacy and the DPDP-RTI interface

Official Secrets Act interface

FACT: The **Official Secrets Act, 1923 remains in force**. The Second ARC's First Report recommended repeal and relocation of genuine official-secrets provisions into a national-security law; that is an authoritative reform recommendation, not enacted law.

FACT: **RTI Section 22** gives the RTI Act overriding effect to the extent of inconsistency with the Official Secrets Act and other instruments. Therefore an OSA label does not end the RTI inquiry. The authority must use RTI's exemption, public-interest, severability and appeal architecture.

ANALYSIS: This does not mean every classified record must be disclosed. Operational security, source safety and foreign confidence can be protected where the statutory test is met.

Privacy after Puttaswamy

FACT: In *Justice K.S. Puttaswamy (Retd.) v Union of India* (nine-judge bench, 24 August 2017), the Supreme Court recognised privacy as a fundamental right. For State information practices, use the legality, legitimate aim, proportionality and procedural-safeguard framework; do not claim that a useful administrative objective alone defeats privacy.

CURRENT: Current DPDP amendment and commencement position

FACT: **DPDP Act, 2023 Section 44(3)** substituted RTI Section 8(1)(j). FACT: MeitY **G.S.R. 843(E), 13 November 2025** commenced Section 44(3) on publication. FACT: The current clause reads: “**information which relates to personal information**”. The former public-activity/unwarranted-invasion/larger-public-interest wording is no longer the text of clause (j).

FACT: Sections **8(2), 10 and 11** remain in the RTI Act. ANALYSIS: Their interaction with the substituted clause must be reasoned carefully. Do not assert that Section 8(2) disappeared; equally, do not assert without authoritative adjudication that it automatically recreates every deleted qualifier.

CURRENT: **Status at 29 August 2026:** the DPDP Act is not wholly operational. G.S.R. 843(E) commenced a specified immediate tranche, including Section 44(3). Its one-year tranche-Section 6(9) and Section 27(1)(d)-commences **13 November 2026**. The eighteen-month tranche includes Sections 3-5, the rest of Section 6, Sections 7-17 and linked core architecture, commencing **13 May 2027**. Ethical duties of necessity, minimisation, accuracy, security and purpose limitation remain valuable before every statutory duty is operational.

PRIVACY-TRANSPARENCY DECISION

Whose information? -> What public function/expenditure? -> What concrete privacy harm?

-> Is disclosure legally available? -> Can masking/aggregation serve the purpose?

-> Give reasons -> preserve appeal

SESSION 10 - Digital information sharing, PYQ routes and answer architecture

10. Digital information sharing, PYQ routes and answer architecture

Ethical sharing checklist

FACT:/ANALYSIS: Government possession is not unlimited permission to circulate:

1. **Authority:** identify the legal/administrative basis.
2. **Purpose:** state the specific service, audit or fraud-control objective.
3. **Necessity:** share only fields genuinely required.
4. **Accuracy/provenance:** identify source, update and correction responsibility.
5. **Access/security:** role-based access, logs, encryption and breach response.
6. **Retention:** delete or archive under a defined schedule; prevent silent repurposing.
7. **Citizen protection:** notice where applicable, human review, correction and grievance remedy.
8. **Public layer:** disclose safe aggregates, methodology, limitations and responsible office.
9. **Review:** periodically test whether linkage still works and remains proportionate.

Example: linking welfare and health databases may identify duplicate records, but a model match should be an investigation lead, not automatic cancellation. Public dashboards should normally use aggregates rather than names or diagnoses.

Direct PYQ ownership and boundaries

- FACT: **2018 Q2(b):** RTI redefines accountability, not empowerment alone.
- FACT: **2019 Q4(b):** OSA as an obstacle to RTI implementation.
- Cross-routes: 2018 public interest; 2018 Snowden disclosure; 2019 institutional ethics systems;

2021 social audit; 2024 ethics code and transparency; 2025 constitutional accountability and public-fund accountability.

- ANALYSIS: Topic 15 supplies information ethics and statutory architecture. Topic 22 retains full

case-study method; Topics 09, 10, 11, 14, 16, 18 and 20 retain their primary concepts.

Answer architecture

DEFINE nearest concepts

- > NAME only relevant RTI sections
- > EXPLAIN information-asymmetry mechanism
- > APPLY one India-centric record/expenditure example
- > BALANCE privacy/security/commercial harm
- > REFORM proactive disclosure + reasons + appeal/remedy
- > CONCLUDE: visible power, protected dignity, correctable decision

Rapid traps

- RTI is not absolute access; privacy is not absolute secrecy.
- Section 11 consultation is not a third-party veto.
- Section 20 is conditional, personal and capped-not automatic.
- Section 24 has corruption and human-rights exceptions.
- Section 22 overrides inconsistency; it did not repeal OSA.
- The 2019 Amendment did not itself state “three years.”
- The 2019 Amendment did not abolish the citizen's right.
- The former Section 8(1)(j) wording is not current after 13 November 2025.
- DPDP is partly commenced, not wholly operational as at 29 August 2026.
- Maximum publication can still be unethical if data are personal, unsafe, unusable or misleading.

Official current-source note

- DoPT, annual programme on propagation of the RTI Act for 2025-26, 17 April 2025:

https://rti.dopt.gov.in/Writereaddata/Guidelines_2025_26.pdf

- MeitY, G.S.R. 843(E), DPDP commencement notification, 13 November 2025:

<https://www.meity.gov.in/static/uploads/2025/11/c56ceae6c383460ca69577428d36828b.pdf>

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

MCQ 1

A department releases one contract only after litigation but keeps criteria and reasons routinely hidden. Which distinction prevents calling the whole institution transparent? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Transparency is the continuing institutional visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and results to appropriate scrutiny; one compelled disclosure may reveal information without changing an organisation's secrecy-oriented default.
- B. Disclosure is the release of specified information to a person or public, whether proactively or on request; it is an instrument of transparency but does not by itself create answerability, correction or consequence.
- C. Information sharing is the authorised movement of information between officials, institutions or persons for a defined function; unlike public disclosure, it may remain restricted and must respect necessity, accuracy, security and privacy.
- D. Accountability exists when an identified actor must explain conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of judgment, correction, remedy or consequence; visibility is enabling evidence, not the completed relationship.

Answer: A

Explanation: Transparency is a systemic condition, not one isolated release is the controlling principle.

Transparency is the continuing institutional visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and results to appropriate scrutiny; one compelled disclosure may reveal information without changing an organisation's secrecy-oriented default. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 2

An agency regularly publishes decision criteria, reasons and outcomes in usable form. Which governance condition is being institutionalised? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Information sharing is the authorised movement of information between officials, institutions or persons for a defined function; unlike public disclosure, it may remain restricted and must respect necessity, accuracy, security and privacy.
- B. Transparency is the continuing institutional visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and results to appropriate scrutiny; one compelled disclosure may reveal information without changing an organisation's secrecy-oriented default.
- C. Accountability exists when an identified actor must explain conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of judgment, correction, remedy or consequence; visibility is enabling evidence, not the completed relationship.
- D. Disclosure is the release of specified information to a person or public, whether proactively or on request; it is an instrument of transparency but does not by itself create answerability, correction or consequence.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Transparency is a systemic condition, not one isolated release** is the controlling principle.

Transparency is the continuing institutional visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and results to appropriate scrutiny; one compelled disclosure may reveal information without changing an organisation's secrecy-oriented default. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 3

A ministry supplies a requested file but no forum can examine the revealed irregularity. What has occurred without completing accountability? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Transparency is the continuing institutional visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and results to appropriate scrutiny; one compelled disclosure may reveal information without changing an organisation's secrecy-oriented default.
- B. Information sharing is the authorised movement of information between officials, institutions or persons for a defined function; unlike public disclosure, it may remain restricted and must respect necessity, accuracy, security and privacy.
- C. Disclosure is the release of specified information to a person or public, whether proactively or on request; it is an instrument of transparency but does not by itself create answerability, correction or consequence.
- D. Accountability exists when an identified actor must explain conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of judgment, correction, remedy or consequence; visibility is enabling evidence, not the completed relationship.

Answer: C

Explanation: **Disclosure is a particular act of making information available** is the controlling principle. Disclosure is the release of specified information to a person or public, whether proactively or on request; it is an instrument of transparency but does not by itself create answerability, correction or consequence. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 4

A public authority uploads a sanctioned project report before any request. Which specific information act has occurred? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Information sharing is the authorised movement of information between officials, institutions or persons for a defined function; unlike public disclosure, it may remain restricted and must respect necessity, accuracy, security and privacy.
- B. Accountability exists when an identified actor must explain conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of judgment, correction, remedy or consequence; visibility is enabling evidence, not the completed relationship.
- C. Transparency is the continuing institutional visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and results to appropriate scrutiny; one compelled disclosure may reveal information without changing an organisation's secrecy-oriented default.
- D. Disclosure is the release of specified information to a person or public, whether proactively or on request; it is an instrument of transparency but does not by itself create answerability, correction or consequence.

Answer: D

Explanation: **Disclosure is a particular act of making information available** is the controlling principle. Disclosure is the release of specified information to a person or public, whether proactively or on request; it is an instrument of transparency but does not by itself create answerability, correction or consequence. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 5

Two departments exchange the minimum verified beneficiary fields under lawful authority without publishing them. Which concept best describes the exchange? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Information sharing is the authorised movement of information between officials, institutions or persons for a defined function; unlike public disclosure, it may remain restricted and must respect necessity, accuracy, security and privacy.
- B. Transparency is the continuing institutional visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and results to appropriate scrutiny; one compelled disclosure may reveal information without changing an organisation's secrecy-oriented default.
- C. Disclosure is the release of specified information to a person or public, whether proactively or on request; it is an instrument of transparency but does not by itself create answerability, correction or consequence.
- D. Accountability exists when an identified actor must explain conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of judgment, correction, remedy or consequence; visibility is enabling evidence, not the completed relationship.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Information sharing is purpose-bound exchange, not automatic publication** is the controlling principle. Information sharing is the authorised movement of information between officials, institutions or persons for a defined function; unlike public disclosure, it may remain restricted and must respect necessity, accuracy, security and privacy. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 6

An officer forwards an entire health database to an unrelated unit merely because both are governmental. Which purpose-bound limitation has failed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Disclosure is the release of specified information to a person or public, whether proactively or on request; it is an instrument of transparency but does not by itself create answerability, correction or consequence.
- B. Information sharing is the authorised movement of information between officials, institutions or persons for a defined function; unlike public disclosure, it may remain restricted and must respect necessity, accuracy, security and privacy.
- C. Accountability exists when an identified actor must explain conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of judgment, correction, remedy or consequence; visibility is enabling evidence, not the completed relationship.
- D. Transparency is the continuing institutional visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and results to appropriate scrutiny; one compelled disclosure may reveal information without changing an organisation's secrecy-oriented default.

Answer: B

Explanation: Information sharing is purpose-bound exchange, not automatic publication is the controlling principle. Information sharing is the authorised movement of information between officials, institutions or persons for a defined function; unlike public disclosure, it may remain restricted and must respect necessity, accuracy, security and privacy. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 7

An expenditure dashboard reveals delay but no officer must answer and no authority can correct it. Which governance element remains incomplete? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Transparency is the continuing institutional visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and results to appropriate scrutiny; one compelled disclosure may reveal information without changing an organisation's secrecy-oriented default.
- B. Disclosure is the release of specified information to a person or public, whether proactively or on request; it is an instrument of transparency but does not by itself create answerability, correction or consequence.
- C. Accountability exists when an identified actor must explain conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of judgment, correction, remedy or consequence; visibility is enabling evidence, not the completed relationship.
- D. Information sharing is the authorised movement of information between officials, institutions or persons for a defined function; unlike public disclosure, it may remain restricted and must respect necessity, accuracy, security and privacy.

Answer: C

Explanation: Accountability requires answerability and a corrective forum is the controlling principle. Accountability exists when an identified actor must explain conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of judgment, correction, remedy or consequence; visibility is enabling evidence, not the completed relationship. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 8

A review body examines disclosed reasons, orders correction and fixes responsibility. Which concept is fully operational? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Disclosure is the release of specified information to a person or public, whether proactively or on request; it is an instrument of transparency but does not by itself create answerability, correction or consequence.
- B. Information sharing is the authorised movement of information between officials, institutions or persons for a defined function; unlike public disclosure, it may remain restricted and must respect necessity, accuracy, security and privacy.
- C. Transparency is the continuing institutional visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and results to appropriate scrutiny; one compelled disclosure may reveal information without changing an organisation's secrecy-oriented default.
- D. Accountability exists when an identified actor must explain conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of judgment, correction, remedy or consequence; visibility is enabling evidence, not the completed relationship.

Answer: D

Explanation: Accountability requires answerability and a corrective forum is the controlling principle. Accountability exists when an identified actor must explain conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of judgment, correction, remedy or consequence; visibility is enabling evidence, not the completed relationship. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 9

A PIO rejects an Indian citizen solely for not proving personal loss from the requested contract. Which statutory starting point corrects the refusal? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Right to Information Act confers the right to information on all citizens; applicants ordinarily need not establish a special interest, although access remains subject to the Act's defined scope and exemptions.
- B. The Act concerns information in material form held by or under the control of a public authority, including accessible private-body material under another law; it does not generally require creation of fresh opinions, analysis or answers.
- C. A request may be made in writing or electronically in English, Hindi or the area's official language; reasons cannot be demanded, assistance is due where needed, and a misdirected request must be transferred promptly.
- D. The ordinary RTI decision period is thirty days, life-or-liberty information is due within forty-eight hours, silence becomes deemed refusal, and information is free when the authority misses the statutory time limit.

Answer: A

Explanation: Section 3 creates a citizen's statutory right is the controlling principle. The Right to Information Act confers the right to information on all citizens; applicants ordinarily need not establish a special interest, although access remains subject to the Act's defined scope and exemptions. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 10

A foreign corporation claims Section 3 in its own right as though citizenship were irrelevant. Which limitation must be noticed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A request may be made in writing or electronically in English, Hindi or the area's official language; reasons cannot be demanded, assistance is due where needed, and a misdirected request must be transferred promptly.
- B. The Right to Information Act confers the right to information on all citizens; applicants ordinarily need not establish a special interest, although access remains subject to the Act's defined scope and exemptions.
- C. The ordinary RTI decision period is thirty days, life-or-liberty information is due within forty-eight hours, silence becomes deemed refusal, and information is free when the authority misses the statutory time limit.
- D. The Act concerns information in material form held by or under the control of a public authority, including accessible private-body material under another law; it does not generally require creation of fresh opinions, analysis or answers.

Answer: B

Explanation: Section 3 creates a citizen's statutory right is the controlling principle. The Right to Information Act confers the right to information on all citizens; applicants ordinarily need not establish a special interest, although access remains subject to the Act's defined scope and exemptions. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 11

An applicant asks a PIO to invent a new economic forecast from raw files. Which boundary applies? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Right to Information Act confers the right to information on all citizens; applicants ordinarily need not establish a special interest, although access remains subject to the Act's defined scope and exemptions.
- B. A request may be made in writing or electronically in English, Hindi or the area's official language; reasons cannot be demanded, assistance is due where needed, and a misdirected request must be transferred promptly.
- C. The Act concerns information in material form held by or under the control of a public authority, including accessible private-body material under another law; it does not generally require creation of fresh opinions, analysis or answers.
- D. The ordinary RTI decision period is thirty days, life-or-liberty information is due within forty-eight hours, silence becomes deemed refusal, and information is free when the authority misses the statutory time limit.

Answer: C

Explanation: RTI reaches existing material held or controlled, not new explanations is the controlling principle. The Act concerns information in material form held by or under the control of a public authority, including accessible private-body material under another law; it does not generally require creation of fresh opinions, analysis or answers. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 12

A regulator can lawfully access a licensee's inspection report under another statute. Which RTI scope principle may bring that existing report within reach? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A request may be made in writing or electronically in English, Hindi or the area's official language; reasons cannot be demanded, assistance is due where needed, and a misdirected request must be transferred promptly.
- B. The ordinary RTI decision period is thirty days, life-or-liberty information is due within forty-eight hours, silence becomes deemed refusal, and information is free when the authority misses the statutory time limit.
- C. The Right to Information Act confers the right to information on all citizens; applicants ordinarily need not establish a special interest, although access remains subject to the Act's defined scope and exemptions.
- D. The Act concerns information in material form held by or under the control of a public authority, including accessible private-body material under another law; it does not generally require creation of fresh opinions, analysis or answers.

Answer: D

Explanation: RTI reaches existing material held or controlled, not new explanations is the controlling principle. The Act concerns information in material form held by or under the control of a public authority, including accessible private-body material under another law; it does not generally require creation of fresh opinions, analysis or answers. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 13

A PIO insists that an applicant reveal why she wants expenditure vouchers. Which Section 6 safeguard is violated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A request may be made in writing or electronically in English, Hindi or the area's official language; reasons cannot be demanded, assistance is due where needed, and a misdirected request must be transferred promptly.
- B. The Right to Information Act confers the right to information on all citizens; applicants ordinarily need not establish a special interest, although access remains subject to the Act's defined scope and exemptions.
- C. The Act concerns information in material form held by or under the control of a public authority, including accessible private-body material under another law; it does not generally require creation of fresh opinions, analysis or answers.
- D. The ordinary RTI decision period is thirty days, life-or-liberty information is due within forty-eight hours, silence becomes deemed refusal, and information is free when the authority misses the statutory time limit.

Answer: A

Explanation: Section 6 minimises applicant burden and requires transfer is the controlling principle. A request may be made in writing or electronically in English, Hindi or the area's official language; reasons cannot be demanded, assistance is due where needed, and a misdirected request must be transferred promptly. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 14

The requested record is held by another public authority and the application is transferred with notice. Which statutory route is illustrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Act concerns information in material form held by or under the control of a public authority, including accessible private-body material under another law; it does not generally require creation of fresh opinions, analysis or answers.
- B. A request may be made in writing or electronically in English, Hindi or the area's official language; reasons cannot be demanded, assistance is due where needed, and a misdirected request must be transferred promptly.
- C. The ordinary RTI decision period is thirty days, life-or-liberty information is due within forty-eight hours, silence becomes deemed refusal, and information is free when the authority misses the statutory time limit.
- D. The Right to Information Act confers the right to information on all citizens; applicants ordinarily need not establish a special interest, although access remains subject to the Act's defined scope and exemptions.

Answer: B

Explanation: Section 6 minimises applicant burden and requires transfer is the controlling principle. A request may be made in writing or electronically in English, Hindi or the area's official language; reasons cannot be demanded, assistance is due where needed, and a misdirected request must be transferred promptly. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 15

A life-saving drug record is withheld for the ordinary thirty-day period despite a demonstrated life-or-liberty nexus. Which timeline applies? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Right to Information Act confers the right to information on all citizens; applicants ordinarily need not establish a special interest, although access remains subject to the Act's defined scope and exemptions.
- B. The Act concerns information in material form held by or under the control of a public authority, including accessible private-body material under another law; it does not generally require creation of fresh opinions, analysis or answers.
- C. The ordinary RTI decision period is thirty days, life-or-liberty information is due within forty-eight hours, silence becomes deemed refusal, and information is free when the authority misses the statutory time limit.
- D. A request may be made in writing or electronically in English, Hindi or the area's official language; reasons cannot be demanded, assistance is due where needed, and a misdirected request must be transferred promptly.

Answer: C

Explanation: Section 7 combines ordinary, urgent and deemed-refusal timelines is the controlling principle. The ordinary RTI decision period is thirty days, life-or-liberty information is due within forty-eight hours, silence becomes deemed refusal, and information is free when the authority misses the statutory time limit. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 16

A PIO gives no decision until after the statutory period and then demands the normal access fee. Which consequence should be considered? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Act concerns information in material form held by or under the control of a public authority, including accessible private-body material under another law; it does not generally require creation of fresh opinions, analysis or answers.
- B. A request may be made in writing or electronically in English, Hindi or the area's official language; reasons cannot be demanded, assistance is due where needed, and a misdirected request must be transferred promptly.
- C. The Right to Information Act confers the right to information on all citizens; applicants ordinarily need not establish a special interest, although access remains subject to the Act's defined scope and exemptions.
- D. The ordinary RTI decision period is thirty days, life-or-liberty information is due within forty-eight hours, silence becomes deemed refusal, and information is free when the authority misses the statutory time limit.

Answer: D

Explanation: Section 7 combines ordinary, urgent and deemed-refusal timelines is the controlling principle. The ordinary RTI decision period is thirty days, life-or-liberty information is due within forty-eight hours, silence becomes deemed refusal, and information is free when the authority misses the statutory time limit. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 17

A department receives thousands of identical applications for already digitised subsidy criteria. Which statutory strategy should be strengthened first? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. RTI requires organised records and specified suo motu publication, with a constant endeavour to provide information proactively so citizens need minimum resort to individual requests.
- B. Proactive transparency requires current, searchable, accessible and intelligible information, not merely scanned dumps or obsolete links; publication without findability, context, disability access or timely updating can become compliance theatre.
- C. Open data emphasises reusable, often machine-readable public datasets, whereas RTI can also secure records, reasons and correspondence not suitable for open release; both remain bounded by lawful confidentiality, security and privacy.
- D. Digitisation can improve search, time stamps, audit trails and simultaneous access, yet poor indexing context, deletion, vendor lock-in, manipulated logs, cyber insecurity and inaccessible interfaces can reproduce opacity electronically.

Answer: A

Explanation: Section 4 makes proactive disclosure the first transparency channel is the controlling principle. RTI requires organised records and specified suo motu publication, with a constant endeavour to provide information proactively so citizens need minimum resort to individual requests. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 18

A ministry publishes functions, decision norms, budget and subsidy details before any request. Which RTI architecture is operating? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Open data emphasises reusable, often machine-readable public datasets, whereas RTI can also secure records, reasons and correspondence not suitable for open release; both remain bounded by lawful confidentiality, security and privacy.
- B. RTI requires organised records and specified suo motu publication, with a constant endeavour to provide information proactively so citizens need minimum resort to individual requests.
- C. Digitisation can improve search, time stamps, audit trails and simultaneous access, yet poor indexing context, deletion, vendor lock-in, manipulated logs, cyber insecurity and inaccessible interfaces can reproduce opacity electronically.
- D. Proactive transparency requires current, searchable, accessible and intelligible information, not merely scanned dumps or obsolete links; publication without findability, context, disability access or timely updating can become compliance theatre.

Answer: B

Explanation: Section 4 makes proactive disclosure the first transparency channel is the controlling principle. RTI requires organised records and specified suo motu publication, with a constant endeavour to provide information proactively so citizens need minimum resort to individual requests. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 19

A website uploads thousands of unsearchable image files without dates or headings. Which quality dimension of transparency is missing? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. RTI requires organised records and specified suo motu publication, with a constant endeavour to provide information proactively so citizens need minimum resort to individual requests.
- B. Open data emphasises reusable, often machine-readable public datasets, whereas RTI can also secure records, reasons and correspondence not suitable for open release; both remain bounded by lawful confidentiality, security and privacy.
- C. Proactive transparency requires current, searchable, accessible and intelligible information, not merely scanned dumps or obsolete links; publication without findability, context, disability access or timely updating can become compliance theatre.
- D. Digitisation can improve search, time stamps, audit trails and simultaneous access, yet poor indexing context, deletion, vendor lock-in, manipulated logs, cyber insecurity and inaccessible interfaces can reproduce opacity electronically.

Answer: C

Explanation: Usability matters alongside publication is the controlling principle. Proactive transparency requires current, searchable, accessible and intelligible information, not merely scanned dumps or obsolete links; publication without findability, context, disability access or timely updating can become compliance theatre. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 20

A portal offers machine-readable data, plain-language metadata, accessible formats and update dates. Which ethical improvement is demonstrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Open data emphasises reusable, often machine-readable public datasets, whereas RTI can also secure records, reasons and correspondence not suitable for open release; both remain bounded by lawful confidentiality, security and privacy.
- B. Digitisation can improve search, time stamps, audit trails and simultaneous access, yet poor indexing context, deletion, vendor lock-in, manipulated logs, cyber insecurity and inaccessible interfaces can reproduce opacity electronically.
- C. RTI requires organised records and specified suo motu publication, with a constant endeavour to provide information proactively so citizens need minimum resort to individual requests.
- D. Proactive transparency requires current, searchable, accessible and intelligible information, not merely scanned dumps or obsolete links; publication without findability, context, disability access or timely updating can become compliance theatre.

Answer: D

Explanation: Usability matters alongside publication is the controlling principle. Proactive transparency requires current, searchable, accessible and intelligible information, not merely scanned dumps or obsolete links; publication without findability, context, disability access or timely updating can become compliance theatre. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 21

A candidate claims a statistical open-data portal eliminates the need for access to recorded reasons. Which distinction corrects the claim? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Open data emphasises reusable, often machine-readable public datasets, whereas RTI can also secure records, reasons and correspondence not suitable for open release; both remain bounded by lawful confidentiality, security and privacy.
- B. RTI requires organised records and specified suo motu publication, with a constant endeavour to provide information proactively so citizens need minimum resort to individual requests.
- C. Proactive transparency requires current, searchable, accessible and intelligible information, not merely scanned dumps or obsolete links; publication without findability, context, disability access or timely updating can become compliance theatre.
- D. Digitisation can improve search, time stamps, audit trails and simultaneous access, yet poor indexing context, deletion, vendor lock-in, manipulated logs, cyber insecurity and inaccessible interfaces can reproduce opacity electronically.

Answer: A

Explanation: Open data and RTI overlap but are not identical is the controlling principle. Open data emphasises reusable, often machine-readable public datasets, whereas RTI can also secure records, reasons and correspondence not suitable for open release; both remain bounded by lawful confidentiality, security and privacy. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 22

A city releases anonymised transport data for reuse while retaining a request route for file-level decisions. Which complementary design is shown? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Proactive transparency requires current, searchable, accessible and intelligible information, not merely scanned dumps or obsolete links; publication without findability, context, disability access or timely updating can become compliance theatre.
- B. Open data emphasises reusable, often machine-readable public datasets, whereas RTI can also secure records, reasons and correspondence not suitable for open release; both remain bounded by lawful confidentiality, security and privacy.
- C. Digitisation can improve search, time stamps, audit trails and simultaneous access, yet poor indexing context, deletion, vendor lock-in, manipulated logs, cyber insecurity and inaccessible interfaces can reproduce opacity electronically.
- D. RTI requires organised records and specified suo motu publication, with a constant endeavour to provide information proactively so citizens need minimum resort to individual requests.

Answer: B

Explanation: Open data and RTI overlap but are not identical is the controlling principle. Open data emphasises reusable, often machine-readable public datasets, whereas RTI can also secure records, reasons and correspondence not suitable for open release; both remain bounded by lawful confidentiality, security and privacy. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 23

A department scans files but cannot search, authenticate or preserve versions. Why has digitisation not ensured transparency? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. RTI requires organised records and specified suo motu publication, with a constant endeavour to provide information proactively so citizens need minimum resort to individual requests.
- B. Proactive transparency requires current, searchable, accessible and intelligible information, not merely scanned dumps or obsolete links; publication without findability, context, disability access or timely updating can become compliance theatre.
- C. Digitisation can improve search, time stamps, audit trails and simultaneous access, yet poor indexing context, deletion, vendor lock-in, manipulated logs, cyber insecurity and inaccessible interfaces can reproduce opacity electronically.
- D. Open data emphasises reusable, often machine-readable public datasets, whereas RTI can also secure records, reasons and correspondence not suitable for open release; both remain bounded by lawful confidentiality, security and privacy.

Answer: C

Explanation: Digital records can reduce opacity but preserve new risks is the controlling principle. Digitisation can improve search, time stamps, audit trails and simultaneous access, yet poor indexing context, deletion, vendor lock-in, manipulated logs, cyber insecurity and inaccessible interfaces can reproduce opacity electronically. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 24

A records system preserves provenance, retention schedules, access logs and exportable formats. Which enabling architecture is strengthened? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Proactive transparency requires current, searchable, accessible and intelligible information, not merely scanned dumps or obsolete links; publication without findability, context, disability access or timely updating can become compliance theatre.
- B. Open data emphasises reusable, often machine-readable public datasets, whereas RTI can also secure records, reasons and correspondence not suitable for open release; both remain bounded by lawful confidentiality, security and privacy.
- C. RTI requires organised records and specified suo motu publication, with a constant endeavour to provide information proactively so citizens need minimum resort to individual requests.
- D. Digitisation can improve search, time stamps, audit trails and simultaneous access, yet poor indexing context, deletion, vendor lock-in, manipulated logs, cyber insecurity and inaccessible interfaces can reproduce opacity electronically.

Answer: D

Explanation: Digital records can reduce opacity but preserve new risks is the controlling principle. Digitisation can improve search, time stamps, audit trails and simultaneous access, yet poor indexing context, deletion, vendor lock-in, manipulated logs, cyber insecurity and inaccessible interfaces can reproduce opacity electronically. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 25

A PIO writes only 'confidential' without identifying a statutory harm or clause. Which exemption discipline is absent? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. RTI exemptions protect defined interests such as security, judicial restrictions, legislative privilege, commercial confidence, fiduciary information, safety, investigation, cabinet material and personal information; withholding needs clause-linked reasoning.
- B. The statutory public-interest override permits access despite official-secrecy law or listed exemptions where disclosure benefit outweighs harm to protected interests; it requires a reasoned balance, not an automatic presumption.
- C. Where an exempt part can reasonably be separated from the remainder, severability requires access to the non-exempt record with notice of reasons, decision-maker, fee and review rights rather than blanket withholding.
- D. Confidential third-party material triggers notice and consideration, but the PIO makes the reasoned decision subject to public-interest and appeal rules; the third party does not possess an absolute veto.

Answer: A

Explanation: Section 8 exemptions are specific protections, not a secrecy slogan is the controlling principle. RTI exemptions protect defined interests such as security, judicial restrictions, legislative privilege, commercial confidence, fiduciary information, safety, investigation, cabinet material and personal information; withholding needs clause-linked reasoning. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 26

Disclosure would reveal a protected source and endanger that person's safety. Which kind of Section 8 interest is legitimately engaged? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Where an exempt part can reasonably be separated from the remainder, severability requires access to the non-exempt record with notice of reasons, decision-maker, fee and review rights rather than blanket withholding.
- B. RTI exemptions protect defined interests such as security, judicial restrictions, legislative privilege, commercial confidence, fiduciary information, safety, investigation, cabinet material and personal information; withholding needs clause-linked reasoning.
- C. Confidential third-party material triggers notice and consideration, but the PIO makes the reasoned decision subject to public-interest and appeal rules; the third party does not possess an absolute veto.
- D. The statutory public-interest override permits access despite official-secrecy law or listed exemptions where disclosure benefit outweighs harm to protected interests; it requires a reasoned balance, not an automatic presumption.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Section 8 exemptions are specific protections, not a secrecy slogan** is the controlling principle. RTI exemptions protect defined interests such as security, judicial restrictions, legislative privilege, commercial confidence, fiduciary information, safety, investigation, cabinet material and personal information; withholding needs clause-linked reasoning. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 27

Evidence of serious public harm is requested, but disclosure also creates a concrete protected risk. Which statutory balance must the authority perform? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. RTI exemptions protect defined interests such as security, judicial restrictions, legislative privilege, commercial confidence, fiduciary information, safety, investigation, cabinet material and personal information; withholding needs clause-linked reasoning.
- B. Where an exempt part can reasonably be separated from the remainder, severability requires access to the non-exempt record with notice of reasons, decision-maker, fee and review rights rather than blanket withholding.
- C. The statutory public-interest override permits access despite official-secrecy law or listed exemptions where disclosure benefit outweighs harm to protected interests; it requires a reasoned balance, not an automatic presumption.
- D. Confidential third-party material triggers notice and consideration, but the PIO makes the reasoned decision subject to public-interest and appeal rules; the third party does not possess an absolute veto.

Answer: C

Explanation: **Section 8(2) retains a statutory public-interest override** is the controlling principle. The statutory public-interest override permits access despite official-secrecy law or listed exemptions where disclosure benefit outweighs harm to protected interests; it requires a reasoned balance, not an automatic presumption. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 28

An applicant asserts that uttering 'public interest' automatically defeats every exemption. Which qualification corrects the claim? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Where an exempt part can reasonably be separated from the remainder, severability requires access to the non-exempt record with notice of reasons, decision-maker, fee and review rights rather than blanket withholding.
- B. Confidential third-party material triggers notice and consideration, but the PIO makes the reasoned decision subject to public-interest and appeal rules; the third party does not possess an absolute veto.
- C. RTI exemptions protect defined interests such as security, judicial restrictions, legislative privilege, commercial confidence, fiduciary information, safety, investigation, cabinet material and personal information; withholding needs clause-linked reasoning.
- D. The statutory public-interest override permits access despite official-secrecy law or listed exemptions where disclosure benefit outweighs harm to protected interests; it requires a reasoned balance, not an automatic presumption.

Answer: D

Explanation: **Section 8(2) retains a statutory public-interest override** is the controlling principle. The statutory public-interest override permits access despite official-secrecy law or listed exemptions where disclosure benefit outweighs harm to protected interests; it requires a reasoned balance, not an automatic presumption. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 29

Only two names in a long inspection report require lawful protection, yet the entire report is denied. Which statutory technique was omitted? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Where an exempt part can reasonably be separated from the remainder, severability requires access to the non-exempt record with notice of reasons, decision-maker, fee and review rights rather than blanket withholding.
- B. RTI exemptions protect defined interests such as security, judicial restrictions, legislative privilege, commercial confidence, fiduciary information, safety, investigation, cabinet material and personal information; withholding needs clause-linked reasoning.
- C. The statutory public-interest override permits access despite official-secrecy law or listed exemptions where disclosure benefit outweighs harm to protected interests; it requires a reasoned balance, not an automatic presumption.
- D. Confidential third-party material triggers notice and consideration, but the PIO makes the reasoned decision subject to public-interest and appeal rules; the third party does not possess an absolute veto.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Section 10 requires severability** is the controlling principle. Where an exempt part can reasonably be separated from the remainder, severability requires access to the non-exempt record with notice of reasons, decision-maker, fee and review rights rather than blanket withholding. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 30

A PIO redacts protected identifiers and releases the remaining findings with appeal details. Which principle is applied? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The statutory public-interest override permits access despite official-secrecy law or listed exemptions where disclosure benefit outweighs harm to protected interests; it requires a reasoned balance, not an automatic presumption.
- B. Where an exempt part can reasonably be separated from the remainder, severability requires access to the non-exempt record with notice of reasons, decision-maker, fee and review rights rather than blanket withholding.
- C. Confidential third-party material triggers notice and consideration, but the PIO makes the reasoned decision subject to public-interest and appeal rules; the third party does not possess an absolute veto.
- D. RTI exemptions protect defined interests such as security, judicial restrictions, legislative privilege, commercial confidence, fiduciary information, safety, investigation, cabinet material and personal information; withholding needs clause-linked reasoning.

Answer: B

Explanation: Section 10 requires severability is the controlling principle. Where an exempt part can reasonably be separated from the remainder, severability requires access to the non-exempt record with notice of reasons, decision-maker, fee and review rights rather than blanket withholding. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 31

A contractor objects to release and the PIO treats objection as automatically conclusive. Which procedural misconception is present? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. RTI exemptions protect defined interests such as security, judicial restrictions, legislative privilege, commercial confidence, fiduciary information, safety, investigation, cabinet material and personal information; withholding needs clause-linked reasoning.
- B. The statutory public-interest override permits access despite official-secrecy law or listed exemptions where disclosure benefit outweighs harm to protected interests; it requires a reasoned balance, not an automatic presumption.
- C. Confidential third-party material triggers notice and consideration, but the PIO makes the reasoned decision subject to public-interest and appeal rules; the third party does not possess an absolute veto.
- D. Where an exempt part can reasonably be separated from the remainder, severability requires access to the non-exempt record with notice of reasons, decision-maker, fee and review rights rather than blanket withholding.

Answer: C

Explanation: Section 11 is consultation, not a third-party veto is the controlling principle. Confidential third-party material triggers notice and consideration, but the PIO makes the reasoned decision subject to public-interest and appeal rules; the third party does not possess an absolute veto. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 32

The PIO notifies the contractor, considers its representation and independently decides disclosure with appeal notice. Which procedure is correctly followed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The statutory public-interest override permits access despite official-secrecy law or listed exemptions where disclosure benefit outweighs harm to protected interests; it requires a reasoned balance, not an automatic presumption.
- B. Where an exempt part can reasonably be separated from the remainder, severability requires access to the non-exempt record with notice of reasons, decision-maker, fee and review rights rather than blanket withholding.
- C. RTI exemptions protect defined interests such as security, judicial restrictions, legislative privilege, commercial confidence, fiduciary information, safety, investigation, cabinet material and personal information; withholding needs clause-linked reasoning.
- D. Confidential third-party material triggers notice and consideration, but the PIO makes the reasoned decision subject to public-interest and appeal rules; the third party does not possess an absolute veto.

Answer: D

Explanation: Section 11 is consultation, not a third-party veto is the controlling principle. Confidential third-party material triggers notice and consideration, but the PIO makes the reasoned decision subject to public-interest and appeal rules; the third party does not possess an absolute veto. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 33

An appellate authority tells the citizen alone to prove that secrecy was unlawful. Which burden rule has been reversed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. RTI provides a first appeal within the public authority and a second appeal to the Information Commission; in appeal proceedings the burden of proving that denial was justified lies on the denying PIO.
- B. The Information Commission may impose two hundred and fifty rupees per day up to twenty-five thousand rupees for specified PIO failures after hearing, unless reasonable and diligent conduct is proved; persistent default may support disciplinary recommendation.
- C. Specified intelligence and security organisations are generally excluded, but information concerning allegations of corruption or human-rights violations is not wholly outside the Act; human-rights disclosure follows Commission approval and a special timeline.
- D. The RTI Amendment Act, 2019 replaced Parliament-fixed tenure and salary links for Central and State Information Commissioners with terms prescribed by the Central Government; the 2019 Rules prescribe a three-year term, subject to the age ceiling.

Answer: A

Explanation: Section 19 makes the PIO justify denial is the controlling principle. RTI provides a first appeal within the public authority and a second appeal to the Information Commission; in appeal proceedings the burden of proving that denial was justified lies on the denying PIO. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 34

A first appellate authority reviews the PIO's reasons before a later Commission appeal. Which two-stage appellate structure is illustrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Specified intelligence and security organisations are generally excluded, but information concerning allegations of corruption or human-rights violations is not wholly outside the Act; human-rights disclosure follows Commission approval and a special timeline.
- B. RTI provides a first appeal within the public authority and a second appeal to the Information Commission; in appeal proceedings the burden of proving that denial was justified lies on the denying PIO.
- C. The RTI Amendment Act, 2019 replaced Parliament-fixed tenure and salary links for Central and State Information Commissioners with terms prescribed by the Central Government; the 2019 Rules prescribe a three-year term, subject to the age ceiling.
- D. The Information Commission may impose two hundred and fifty rupees per day up to twenty-five thousand rupees for specified PIO failures after hearing, unless reasonable and diligent conduct is proved; persistent default may support disciplinary recommendation.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Section 19 makes the PIO justify denial** is the controlling principle. RTI provides a first appeal within the public authority and a second appeal to the Information Commission; in appeal proceedings the burden of proving that denial was justified lies on the denying PIO. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 35

A note says every delayed reply automatically fines the department without hearing. Which penalty qualifications are missing? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. RTI provides a first appeal within the public authority and a second appeal to the Information Commission; in appeal proceedings the burden of proving that denial was justified lies on the denying PIO.
- B. Specified intelligence and security organisations are generally excluded, but information concerning allegations of corruption or human-rights violations is not wholly outside the Act; human-rights disclosure follows Commission approval and a special timeline.
- C. The Information Commission may impose two hundred and fifty rupees per day up to twenty-five thousand rupees for specified PIO failures after hearing, unless reasonable and diligent conduct is proved; persistent default may support disciplinary recommendation.
- D. The RTI Amendment Act, 2019 replaced Parliament-fixed tenure and salary links for Central and State Information Commissioners with terms prescribed by the Central Government; the 2019 Rules prescribe a three-year term, subject to the age ceiling.

Answer: C

Explanation: **Section 20 penalty is personal, conditional and capped** is the controlling principle. The Information Commission may impose two hundred and fifty rupees per day up to twenty-five thousand rupees for specified PIO failures after hearing, unless reasonable and diligent conduct is proved; persistent default may support disciplinary recommendation. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 36

A PIO knowingly destroys requested information and cannot show reasonable diligence. Which Section 20 consequence may arise? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Specified intelligence and security organisations are generally excluded, but information concerning allegations of corruption or human-rights violations is not wholly outside the Act; human-rights disclosure follows Commission approval and a special timeline.
- B. The RTI Amendment Act, 2019 replaced Parliament-fixed tenure and salary links for Central and State Information Commissioners with terms prescribed by the Central Government; the 2019 Rules prescribe a three-year term, subject to the age ceiling.
- C. RTI provides a first appeal within the public authority and a second appeal to the Information Commission; in appeal proceedings the burden of proving that denial was justified lies on the denying PIO.
- D. The Information Commission may impose two hundred and fifty rupees per day up to twenty-five thousand rupees for specified PIO failures after hearing, unless reasonable and diligent conduct is proved; persistent default may support disciplinary recommendation.

Answer: D

Explanation: Section 20 penalty is personal, conditional and capped is the controlling principle. The Information Commission may impose two hundred and fifty rupees per day up to twenty-five thousand rupees for specified PIO failures after hearing, unless reasonable and diligent conduct is proved; persistent default may support disciplinary recommendation. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 37

An authority claims a Second Schedule organisation can never face any RTI request. Which exceptions defeat the absolute proposition? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Specified intelligence and security organisations are generally excluded, but information concerning allegations of corruption or human-rights violations is not wholly outside the Act; human-rights disclosure follows Commission approval and a special timeline.
- B. RTI provides a first appeal within the public authority and a second appeal to the Information Commission; in appeal proceedings the burden of proving that denial was justified lies on the denying PIO.
- C. The Information Commission may impose two hundred and fifty rupees per day up to twenty-five thousand rupees for specified PIO failures after hearing, unless reasonable and diligent conduct is proved; persistent default may support disciplinary recommendation.
- D. The RTI Amendment Act, 2019 replaced Parliament-fixed tenure and salary links for Central and State Information Commissioners with terms prescribed by the Central Government; the 2019 Rules prescribe a three-year term, subject to the age ceiling.

Answer: A

Explanation: Section 24 exclusion has corruption and human-rights exceptions is the controlling principle. Specified intelligence and security organisations are generally excluded, but information concerning allegations of corruption or human-rights violations is not wholly outside the Act; human-rights disclosure follows Commission approval and a special timeline. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 38

A human-rights allegation involving an excluded organisation is routed for the required Commission approval. Which special architecture is engaged? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Information Commission may impose two hundred and fifty rupees per day up to twenty-five thousand rupees for specified PIO failures after hearing, unless reasonable and diligent conduct is proved; persistent default may support disciplinary recommendation.
- B. Specified intelligence and security organisations are generally excluded, but information concerning allegations of corruption or human-rights violations is not wholly outside the Act; human-rights disclosure follows Commission approval and a special timeline.
- C. The RTI Amendment Act, 2019 replaced Parliament-fixed tenure and salary links for Central and State Information Commissioners with terms prescribed by the Central Government; the 2019 Rules prescribe a three-year term, subject to the age ceiling.
- D. RTI provides a first appeal within the public authority and a second appeal to the Information Commission; in appeal proceedings the burden of proving that denial was justified lies on the denying PIO.

Answer: B

Explanation: Section 24 exclusion has corruption and human-rights exceptions is the controlling principle. Specified intelligence and security organisations are generally excluded, but information concerning allegations of corruption or human-rights violations is not wholly outside the Act; human-rights disclosure follows Commission approval and a special timeline. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 39

A candidate says the Amendment itself wrote 'three years' into Sections 13 and 16. Which statute-versus-rule distinction corrects the answer? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. RTI provides a first appeal within the public authority and a second appeal to the Information Commission; in appeal proceedings the burden of proving that denial was justified lies on the denying PIO.
- B. The Information Commission may impose two hundred and fifty rupees per day up to twenty-five thousand rupees for specified PIO failures after hearing, unless reasonable and diligent conduct is proved; persistent default may support disciplinary recommendation.
- C. The RTI Amendment Act, 2019 replaced Parliament-fixed tenure and salary links for Central and State Information Commissioners with terms prescribed by the Central Government; the 2019 Rules prescribe a three-year term, subject to the age ceiling.
- D. Specified intelligence and security organisations are generally excluded, but information concerning allegations of corruption or human-rights violations is not wholly outside the Act; human-rights disclosure follows Commission approval and a special timeline.

Answer: C

Explanation: The 2019 amendment shifted service-condition detail to rules is the controlling principle. The RTI Amendment Act, 2019 replaced Parliament-fixed tenure and salary links for Central and State Information Commissioners with terms prescribed by the Central Government; the 2019 Rules prescribe a three-year term, subject to the age ceiling. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 40

A critic focuses on executive rule-making over watchdog tenure rather than abolition of RTI rights. Which institutional issue is being identified? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The Information Commission may impose two hundred and fifty rupees per day up to twenty-five thousand rupees for specified PIO failures after hearing, unless reasonable and diligent conduct is proved; persistent default may support disciplinary recommendation.
- B. Specified intelligence and security organisations are generally excluded, but information concerning allegations of corruption or human-rights violations is not wholly outside the Act; human-rights disclosure follows Commission approval and a special timeline.
- C. RTI provides a first appeal within the public authority and a second appeal to the Information Commission; in appeal proceedings the burden of proving that denial was justified lies on the denying PIO.
- D. The RTI Amendment Act, 2019 replaced Parliament-fixed tenure and salary links for Central and State Information Commissioners with terms prescribed by the Central Government; the 2019 Rules prescribe a three-year term, subject to the age ceiling.

Answer: D

Explanation: The 2019 amendment shifted service-condition detail to rules is the controlling principle. The RTI Amendment Act, 2019 replaced Parliament-fixed tenure and salary links for Central and State Information Commissioners with terms prescribed by the Central Government; the 2019 Rules prescribe a three-year term, subject to the age ceiling. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 41

A department invokes the OSA label alone and refuses to examine Sections 8 and 10. Which interface rule is ignored? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The RTI Act overrides inconsistent provisions, including official-secrecy law, while the OSA remains in force; genuine protected interests must therefore be tested through RTI's exemption architecture.
- B. Privacy protects dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information, while transparency checks public power and expenditure; a sound decision identifies whose privacy, what public function and whether narrower disclosure can serve the interest.
- C. From 13 November 2025, the DPDP amendment substituted the RTI personal-information exemption with 'information which relates to personal information'; public-interest, severability and third-party provisions remain, requiring careful legal reasoning.
- D. Government possession does not create unlimited permission to circulate data; ethical information sharing should have lawful authority, a defined purpose, minimum necessary fields, accuracy, access control, retention limits, security and an auditable remedy route.

Answer: A

Explanation: Section 22 displaces inconsistent secrecy law without repealing it is the controlling principle. The RTI Act overrides inconsistent provisions, including official-secrecy law, while the OSA remains in force; genuine protected interests must therefore be tested through RTI's exemption architecture. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 42

An answer says Parliament repealed the OSA when enacting RTI. Which legal correction is required? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. From 13 November 2025, the DPDP amendment substituted the RTI personal-information exemption with 'information which relates to personal information'; public-interest, severability and third-party provisions remain, requiring careful legal reasoning.
- B. The RTI Act overrides inconsistent provisions, including official-secrecy law, while the OSA remains in force; genuine protected interests must therefore be tested through RTI's exemption architecture.
- C. Government possession does not create unlimited permission to circulate data; ethical information sharing should have lawful authority, a defined purpose, minimum necessary fields, accuracy, access control, retention limits, security and an auditable remedy route.
- D. Privacy protects dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information, while transparency checks public power and expenditure; a sound decision identifies whose privacy, what public function and whether narrower disclosure can serve the interest.

Answer: B

Explanation: Section 22 displaces inconsistent secrecy law without repealing it is the controlling principle. The RTI Act overrides inconsistent provisions, including official-secrecy law, while the OSA remains in force; genuine protected interests must therefore be tested through RTI's exemption architecture. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 43

A request seeks a public servant's unrelated medical details merely to attract attention. Which competing value requires serious weight? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The RTI Act overrides inconsistent provisions, including official-secrecy law, while the OSA remains in force; genuine protected interests must therefore be tested through RTI's exemption architecture.
- B. From 13 November 2025, the DPDP amendment substituted the RTI personal-information exemption with 'information which relates to personal information'; public-interest, severability and third-party provisions remain, requiring careful legal reasoning.
- C. Privacy protects dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information, while transparency checks public power and expenditure; a sound decision identifies whose privacy, what public function and whether narrower disclosure can serve the interest.
- D. Government possession does not create unlimited permission to circulate data; ethical information sharing should have lawful authority, a defined purpose, minimum necessary fields, accuracy, access control, retention limits, security and an auditable remedy route.

Answer: C

Explanation: Privacy and transparency protect different democratic goods is the controlling principle. Privacy protects dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information, while transparency checks public power and expenditure; a sound decision identifies whose privacy, what public function and whether narrower disclosure can serve the interest. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 44

A record of public expenditure includes beneficiary identifiers that can be masked without hiding aggregate delivery. Which balancing method is preferable? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. From 13 November 2025, the DPDP amendment substituted the RTI personal-information exemption with 'information which relates to personal information'; public-interest, severability and third-party provisions remain, requiring careful legal reasoning.
- B. Government possession does not create unlimited permission to circulate data; ethical information sharing should have lawful authority, a defined purpose, minimum necessary fields, accuracy, access control, retention limits, security and an auditable remedy route.
- C. The RTI Act overrides inconsistent provisions, including official-secrecy law, while the OSA remains in force; genuine protected interests must therefore be tested through RTI's exemption architecture.
- D. Privacy protects dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information, while transparency checks public power and expenditure; a sound decision identifies whose privacy, what public function and whether narrower disclosure can serve the interest.

Answer: D

Explanation: Privacy and transparency protect different democratic goods is the controlling principle. Privacy protects dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information, while transparency checks public power and expenditure; a sound decision identifies whose privacy, what public function and whether narrower disclosure can serve the interest. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 45

A current answer reproduces only the former public-activity and larger-public-interest wording of clause (j). Which date-stamped correction is necessary? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. From 13 November 2025, the DPDP amendment substituted the RTI personal-information exemption with 'information which relates to personal information'; public-interest, severability and third-party provisions remain, requiring careful legal reasoning.
- B. The RTI Act overrides inconsistent provisions, including official-secrecy law, while the OSA remains in force; genuine protected interests must therefore be tested through RTI's exemption architecture.
- C. Privacy protects dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information, while transparency checks public power and expenditure; a sound decision identifies whose privacy, what public function and whether narrower disclosure can serve the interest.
- D. Government possession does not create unlimited permission to circulate data; ethical information sharing should have lawful authority, a defined purpose, minimum necessary fields, accuracy, access control, retention limits, security and an auditable remedy route.

Answer: A

Explanation: DPDP Section 44(3) changed the text of RTI Section 8(1)(j) is the controlling principle. From 13 November 2025, the DPDP amendment substituted the RTI personal-information exemption with 'information which relates to personal information'; public-interest, severability and third-party provisions remain, requiring careful legal reasoning. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 46

A candidate says the substitution repealed every other RTI balancing and procedural provision. Which surviving architecture disproves the claim? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Privacy protects dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information, while transparency checks public power and expenditure; a sound decision identifies whose privacy, what public function and whether narrower disclosure can serve the interest.
- B. From 13 November 2025, the DPDP amendment substituted the RTI personal-information exemption with 'information which relates to personal information'; public-interest, severability and third-party provisions remain, requiring careful legal reasoning.
- C. Government possession does not create unlimited permission to circulate data; ethical information sharing should have lawful authority, a defined purpose, minimum necessary fields, accuracy, access control, retention limits, security and an auditable remedy route.
- D. The RTI Act overrides inconsistent provisions, including official-secrecy law, while the OSA remains in force; genuine protected interests must therefore be tested through RTI's exemption architecture.

Answer: B

Explanation: DPDP Section 44(3) changed the text of RTI Section 8(1)(j) is the controlling principle. From 13 November 2025, the DPDP amendment substituted the RTI personal-information exemption with 'information which relates to personal information'; public-interest, severability and third-party provisions remain, requiring careful legal reasoning. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 47

A welfare database is copied to an unrelated publicity unit because both belong to government. Which information-sharing safeguard fails first? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The RTI Act overrides inconsistent provisions, including official-secrecy law, while the OSA remains in force; genuine protected interests must therefore be tested through RTI's exemption architecture.
- B. Privacy protects dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information, while transparency checks public power and expenditure; a sound decision identifies whose privacy, what public function and whether narrower disclosure can serve the interest.
- C. Government possession does not create unlimited permission to circulate data; ethical information sharing should have lawful authority, a defined purpose, minimum necessary fields, accuracy, access control, retention limits, security and an auditable remedy route.
- D. From 13 November 2025, the DPDP amendment substituted the RTI personal-information exemption with 'information which relates to personal information'; public-interest, severability and third-party provisions remain, requiring careful legal reasoning.

Answer: C

Explanation: Purpose limitation governs inter-departmental sharing is the controlling principle. Government possession does not create unlimited permission to circulate data; ethical information sharing should have lawful authority, a defined purpose, minimum necessary fields, accuracy, access control, retention limits, security and an auditable remedy route. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 48

Two agencies share verified minimum fields under a recorded legal purpose with access logs and correction. Which governance model is demonstrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Privacy protects dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information, while transparency checks public power and expenditure; a sound decision identifies whose privacy, what public function and whether narrower disclosure can serve the interest.
- B. From 13 November 2025, the DPDP amendment substituted the RTI personal-information exemption with 'information which relates to personal information'; public-interest, severability and third-party provisions remain, requiring careful legal reasoning.
- C. The RTI Act overrides inconsistent provisions, including official-secrecy law, while the OSA remains in force; genuine protected interests must therefore be tested through RTI's exemption architecture.
- D. Government possession does not create unlimited permission to circulate data; ethical information sharing should have lawful authority, a defined purpose, minimum necessary fields, accuracy, access control, retention limits, security and an auditable remedy route.

Answer: D

Explanation: Purpose limitation governs inter-departmental sharing is the controlling principle. Government possession does not create unlimited permission to circulate data; ethical information sharing should have lawful authority, a defined purpose, minimum necessary fields, accuracy, access control, retention limits, security and an auditable remedy route. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q2(a): What is meant by public interest? What are the principles and procedures to be followed by the civil servants in public interest? (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\more_previous_papers\GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV.pdf, page 2. Topic 09 is the primary public-service-values owner; Topic 15 uses it only for disclosure balancing.

Model solution

Public interest is constitutionally permissible common welfare assessed through evidence, rights and fair distribution, not the preference of an official, a powerful group or a bare numerical majority. It includes vulnerable, remote and future citizens who may lack an effective voice.

A civil servant should first identify lawful authority and the affected interests. She should collect relevant facts, disclose material conflicts, consult affected groups where feasible, compare less restrictive alternatives, apply objective criteria and record reasons. Equality, dignity, proportionality, economy and long-term effects should guide the choice. Transparency requires publication of non-sensitive criteria and outcomes; privacy or security restrictions must be specific and no wider than necessary. An appeal or review route should correct exclusion.

For example, releasing a village-wise relief list may expose diversion, but unnecessary medical details should be masked. Public interest therefore does not mean maximum disclosure or maximum secrecy. It is a reasoned constitutional judgment whose evidence, procedure and balance are capable of scrutiny.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2018 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q2(b): "The Right to Information Act is not all about citizens' empowerment alone, it essentially redefines the concept of accountability." Discuss. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against

books\more_previous_papers\GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV.pdf, page 2. This is Topic 15's direct historical PYQ.

Model solution

RTI empowers a citizen to seek existing records, but its deeper contribution is to change the relationship between public authority and citizen. Section 4 requires organised records and proactive disclosure; Sections 6 and 7 create a time-bound request route; Section 19 supplies appeal; and Section 20 can attach personal consequence to specified PIO failures. The authority, rather than the applicant, must justify withholding under a statutory exemption.

This makes decisions traceable. Tender criteria, beneficiary lists, expenditure and recorded reasons can be compared with law and actual delivery. MKSS-style verification of muster rolls illustrates how information becomes evidence for social accountability. Yet disclosure alone is not complete accountability: a competent forum must hear, judge, correct and remedy the revealed failure.

Privacy, security and other protected interests also require narrow, reasoned treatment, including severability. RTI therefore redefines accountability by moving administration from discretionary secrecy toward documented answerability, while remaining one component of a wider audit, grievance and remedial system.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2018 - 20 marks

Question: GS-IV Q12: Edward Snowden, a computer expert and former CIA systems administrator, released confidential Government documents to the press about the existence of Government surveillance programmes. According to many legal experts and the US Government, his actions violated the Espionage Act of 1917, which identified the leak of State secrets as an act of treason. Yet, despite the fact that he broke the law, Snowden argued that he had a moral obligation to act. He gave a justification for his "whistle blowing" by stating that he had a duty "to inform the public as to that which is done in their name and that which is done against them." According to Snowden, the Government's violation of privacy had to be exposed regardless of legality since more substantive issues of social action and public morality were involved here. Many agreed with Snowden. Few argued that he broke the law and compromised national security, for which he should be held accountable. Do you agree that Snowden's actions were ethically justified even if legally prohibited? Why or why not? Make an argument by weighing the competing values in this case. (Answer in 250 words)

Source / ownership: Exact full case verified against

books\more_previous_papers\GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV.pdf, page 11. Topic 10 and Topic 22 own conscience and full case method; Topic 15 owns the disclosure-secrecy-privacy boundary. The stem's legal characterisations are not independently asserted as settled conclusions.

Model solution

The case opposes privacy, informed democratic consent and exposure of possible abuse to legality, official confidentiality, institutional loyalty and national security. A disclosure is not ethical merely because the discloser invokes conscience; nor does classification automatically defeat a serious public-interest claim.

The decision should test the gravity and evidence of the alleged wrong, the availability and safety of internal or independent oversight channels, necessity of external disclosure, reliability of the material, and proportionality of what is revealed. Information unrelated to the wrongdoing should be minimised or redacted. Consequentialism weighs democratic correction against operational and personal harm; duty ethics recognises duties of truth and confidentiality; virtue ethics requires courage joined with prudence.

For an Indian administrator, the normal route is to preserve evidence, record objection and use competent vigilance, legislative, judicial or protected-reporting channels. External disclosure becomes morally stronger where grave illegality is evidenced, ordinary remedies are ineffective and release is narrowly tailored. The defensible verdict is therefore conditional: exposing unlawful surveillance may serve public morality, but indiscriminate publication that

creates avoidable security or privacy harm remains unjustified. Independent review and severability offer the best reconciliation.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2019 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q4(b): There is a view that the Official Secrets Act is an obstacle to the implementation of Right to Information Act. Do you agree with the view? Discuss. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM19-GeneralStudies-IV.pdf, page 3. This is Topic 15's direct PYQ; Citizens' Charter in Q4(a) is excluded.

Model solution

The view is substantially persuasive as an administrative-culture critique, but it needs a legal qualification. The Official Secrets Act, 1923 remains in force and can reinforce classification, fear of disclosure and a colonial need-to-know mindset. The Second ARC therefore recommended its repeal and relocation of genuine secrecy offences into a national-security law.

Legally, however, OSA is not an automatic answer to an RTI request. Section 22 gives the RTI Act overriding effect to the extent of inconsistency. Withholding must be justified through a relevant RTI exemption, while Section 8(2) permits disclosure where public interest outweighs harm. Section 10 requires release of a reasonably severable non-exempt part.

National security, protected sources and operational details can require secrecy; transparency does not mean indiscriminate release. Reform should narrow classification, record reasons, review secrecy periodically, train PIOs and strengthen independent appeal. Thus the chief obstacle is not coexistence alone but using the OSA label to bypass RTI's clause-specific, harm-based and reviewable architecture.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2019 - 20 marks

Question: GS-IV Q12: In recent times, there has been an increasing concern in India to develop effective civil service ethics, codes of conduct, transparency measures, ethics and integrity systems and anti-corruption agencies. In view of this, there is a need being felt to focus on three specific areas, which are directly relevant to the problems of internalizing integrity and ethics in the civil services. These are as follows: 1. Anticipating specific threats to ethical standards and integrity in the civil services, 2. Strengthening the ethical competence of civil servants and 3. Developing administrative processes and practices which promote ethical values and integrity in civil services. Suggest institutional measures to address the above three issues. (Answer in 250 words)

Source / ownership: Faithful English text and numbering verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM19-GeneralStudies-IV.pdf, page 7. Topic 16/20 own the full ethics-system demand; Topic 15 contributes transparency and information architecture.

Model solution

The three demands require a prevention-capability-process architecture. First, departments should map risks around procurement, transfers, licensing, data access and conflicts of interest. Published criteria, rotation in sensitive posts, conflict registers, electronic audit trails, protected reporting and risk-based vigilance can expose threats before loss occurs.

Second, ethical competence needs induction and recurring dilemma-based training, confidential ethics advice, mentoring and leadership by example. Officers should practise giving speaking reasons, balancing RTI with privacy, managing conflicts and using lawful dissent channels. Training should be evaluated through decisions and institutional outcomes, not attendance.

Third, processes should reduce opaque discretion: Section 4-style proactive disclosure, accessible service standards, e-procurement, reasoned orders, record-retention rules, independent audit, time-bound appeal and grievance remedy.

Information systems must show decision ownership without exposing protected personal or security data. Social audit can compare official records with delivery where the function permits citizen verification.

No agency alone can manufacture integrity. Excessive surveillance may chill honest judgment, while publication without correction becomes theatre. Controls should therefore be proportionate, protect documented good faith and link disclosure to a competent forum, remedy and learning. Ethical culture becomes durable when character is supported by reviewable institutional design.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2021 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q6(a): An independent and empowered social audit mechanism is an absolute must in every sphere of public service, including judiciary, to ensure performance, accountability and ethical conduct. Elaborate. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-21-GENSTUDIESPAPER-IV-110122.pdf, page 3. Topic 11 is primary; Topic 15 supplies the records-and-disclosure precondition.

Model solution

Social audit enables citizens to compare official records with lived delivery. Independence from the implementing body, proactive access to intelligible records, field verification and a public hearing can expose ghost entries, exclusion and poor performance hidden by aggregate reports. MGNREGA workers, for example, may compare job cards, muster rolls, wages and completed works.

Information is necessary but insufficient. Empowerment requires a time-bound action-taken report, correction or compensation, recovery or disciplinary referral where evidence supports it, reasoned rejection of unsupported claims and protection against intimidation. Privacy-sensitive identifiers should be minimised or masked where public verification does not require them.

The phrase 'every sphere' must be functionally adapted. Citizen scrutiny of court administration cannot become crowd control of adjudication; decisional independence, confidentiality and lawful appeal remain. Social audit complements CAG, departmental audit and courts. Its ethical value lies in converting usable disclosure into participatory verification and enforceable follow-up.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2024 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q5(a): The 'Code of Conduct' and 'Code of Ethics' are the sources of guidance in public administration. There is code of conduct already in operation, whereas code of ethics is not yet put in place. Suggest a suitable model for code of ethics to maintain integrity, probity and transparency in governance. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\mains\05 UPSC 2024 Paper-IV_Final 1.pdf, page 3. Topic 16 is primary; Topic 15 contributes openness, information-use and review.

Model solution

A Code of Ethics should begin with constitutional fidelity and public purpose, then state selflessness, integrity, merit objectivity, impartiality, openness, honest interest declaration, accountability and leadership by example. Its transparency chapter should require publication of decision criteria, speaking reasons, accurate records, lawful RTI assistance and responsible use of confidential and personal information.

Implementation matters more than a declaration. Officers need dilemma training, confidential ethics advice, interest registers, recusal protocols, secure reporting, independent complaint handling, fair inquiry and an annual account of observance. Proactive disclosure should be current and intelligible, while privacy, security and fiduciary limits are applied through stated law rather than generic secrecy.

A Code of Conduct remains complementary because it specifies prohibited behaviour, procedures and consequences. Neither code can replace the RTI Act, service rules or due process. The suitable model therefore joins values with records, institutional advice, review and remedy, making claimed ethical standards visible without treating maximum publicity as maximum probity.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2025 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q1(b): "Constitutional morality is not a natural sentiment but a product of civil education and adherence of the rule of law." Examine the significance of constitutional morality for public servant highlighting the role in promoting good governance and ensuring accountability in public administration. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact English wording, including the printed 'adherence', verified against books\mains\UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf, page 2. Topic 10/14 are primary; Topic 15 uses the public-reasons and accountability cross-link.

Model solution

Constitutional morality is learned fidelity to constitutional values, procedures and limits on power rather than obedience to private preference or a temporary majority. For a public servant it turns equality, dignity, liberty and rule of law into daily decision standards.

It promotes good governance by requiring lawful competence, objective criteria, fair hearing, public reasons and review. These disciplines restrain arbitrary discretion and protect minorities even where local prejudice is popular. Accountability improves because a decision leaves a record that citizens, auditors and appellate bodies can test. A district officer allocating relief should publish need-based criteria, record exclusions, protect unnecessary personal data and provide a grievance route.

Constitutional morality is not mechanical publicity or rule worship. Sensitive information may be withheld under law, and humane discretion may be needed, but both require proportionate reasons and review. It thus makes transparency purposeful: information enables citizens to examine whether public power remained within constitutional values and to obtain correction when it did not.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2025 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q6(b): India is an emerging economic power of the world as it has recently secured the status of fourth largest economy of the world as per IMF projection. However, it has been observed that in some sectors, allocated funds remain either underutilised or misutilised. What specific measures would you recommend for ensuring accountability in this regard to stop leakages and gaining the status of third largest economy of the world in near future? (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Wording verified from books\mains\UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf, pages 3-4; the scan's text layer drops part of one printed line. Topic 18 is primary and Topic 11 owns general accountability; Topic 15 supplies disclosure and information-system measures.

Model solution

Public-fund accountability begins by naming responsibility for sanction, release, utilisation, output and outcome. Each budget head should have realistic milestones, interoperable expenditure records and a reviewing officer.

E-procurement, time-stamped transaction trails and exception alerts can identify idle balances, duplicate payments and delay.

Visibility must reach citizens and competent forums. Departments should proactively publish scheme-wise allocations, releases, physical progress, utilisation and audit responses in accessible, machine-readable form, subject to legitimate redaction. CAG and legislative scrutiny, field verification, social audit and protected complaints should test the data. Deviations require speaking explanations, time-bound correction, recovery or disciplinary referral where evidence supports it, and restoration of affected service.

Dashboards alone may contain poor or strategically reported data. Independent verification, data-quality responsibility, grievance appeal and outcome evaluation are essential. Information sharing across treasury, procurement and implementing units should be purpose-bound and secure. Thus transparency supports growth only when it matures into answerability, judgment and remedy.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: Distinguish transparency, disclosure, information sharing and accountability in public administration. Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Transparency is the continuing visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and outcomes to appropriate scrutiny.

Disclosure is a particular act of releasing specified information, proactively or on request. Information sharing is the authorised movement of information for a defined function; it may occur between departments without becoming public. Accountability is the relationship in which an identified actor explains conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of correction, remedy or consequence.

The distinctions are practical. Publishing a tender is disclosure and may strengthen transparency. Sharing verified bidder debarment data with another authorised buyer is purpose-bound information sharing. If an audit body examines the award, hears the officer and orders correction, accountability is completed. Conversely, a data dump without reasons may disclose much while remaining opaque.

Privacy and security qualify each process: public access may require redaction, while restricted sharing needs lawful purpose, minimum fields and access controls. Therefore transparency supplies visibility, disclosure and sharing move information, and accountability converts relevant information into answerable and correctable public power.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 10 marks

Question: Why is Section 4 proactive disclosure ethically superior to excessive dependence on individual RTI applications? Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Section 4 places the burden of routine openness on the public authority rather than on a citizen who must know what to ask, draft an application and pursue delay. Organised records and regular publication of functions, norms, budgets, subsidies, concessions and decision processes reduce information asymmetry before suspicion or litigation arises.

Proactive disclosure promotes equality because persons with less legal literacy, money or time gain the same baseline information. It also reduces repetitive applications and PIO workload, supports media and social audit, and disciplines officials who know that criteria and outcomes will be visible. Publishing ward-wise works and expenditure, for example, lets residents compare records with the site.

Its ethical superiority is conditional. Obsolete links, scanned dumps and unexplained datasets create compliance theatre; personal data and genuine security interests require lawful protection. Authorities should therefore publish current, searchable, accessible and machine-readable material with metadata, review dates and grievance routes. Individual RTI remains necessary for file-specific records. Section 4 is the first channel, not a substitute for request, appeal and remedy.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 15 marks

Question: Examine how Sections 8(2), 10 and 11 prevent both absolute secrecy and reckless disclosure under the RTI Act. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

The RTI Act does not choose between disclosure of everything and secrecy by label. Section 8(1) protects specified interests, but Section 8(2) permits access where public interest in disclosure outweighs harm to those interests, notwithstanding the Official Secrets Act or the listed exemptions. The authority must therefore identify the protected harm and weigh it against a concrete public benefit.

Section 10 narrows withholding. If protected names, coordinates or trade details can reasonably be separated, the remainder must be supplied with reasons and review information. It prevents one exempt sentence from concealing an entire report. Section 11 adds procedural fairness where confidential third-party material may be released: notice and representation inform the PIO's decision, but objection is not an absolute veto.

Consider a completed public-works contract containing a proprietary technique and evidence of inflated payment. The PIO should hear the contractor, protect genuinely competitive material, sever it where possible and assess public interest in expenditure disclosure. The applicant and third party retain appeal rights.

These provisions demand reasoned calibration. Section 8(2) is not a magic phrase, severability must be practicable, and consultation must not outsource the statutory decision. Together they make secrecy exceptional, disclosure proportionate and the process reviewable.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 4 - 15 marks

Question: Assess the institutional-independence implications of the RTI (Amendment) Act, 2019 without overstating its effect. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Before 2019, the RTI Act itself fixed the tenure of the Chief Information Commissioner and Information Commissioners and linked their salaries to specified constitutional or senior offices. The Amendment changed Sections 13 and 16 so that tenure, salary, allowances and service conditions for Central and State Commissions are prescribed by the Central Government. The 2019 Rules, not the Amendment's text, prescribe a three-year term subject to the age ceiling.

The ethical concern is structural. Information Commissions decide appeals involving public authorities, including governments. Moving safeguards from Parliament-fixed text to executive rules can reduce the appearance or durability of insulation and may create a chilling-risk argument. Central prescription for State commissioners also raises a federal-design concern.

However, the Amendment did not abolish the citizen's right, exemptions, appeals or penalty power, and a rule-making change does not prove actual interference in any decision. Administrative uniformity and flexibility are legitimate counterclaims. Independence also depends on transparent appointments, vacancies, resources, reasoned orders and review, not tenure alone.

A balanced reform would place core tenure and remuneration safeguards in statute, ensure timely merit-based appointments and publish performance information while preserving adjudicatory autonomy. The defensible conclusion is a serious institutional-design concern, not an allegation of established misconduct.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 5 - 20 marks

Question: Privacy is not an exemption from accountability, and transparency is not a licence for personal-data exposure. Discuss after Puttaswamy and the DPDP-driven amendment to RTI Section 8(1)(j). Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

Privacy and transparency protect different constitutional-democratic goods. Privacy preserves dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information; transparency exposes the exercise of public power and public money. Puttaswamy recognised privacy as a fundamental right, requiring State intrusion to rest on legality, legitimate aim, proportionality and safeguards. Yet public office cannot convert every service-related record into a private enclave.

DPDP Act Section 44(3), commenced on 13 November 2025, substituted RTI Section 8(1)(j) with the broader text 'information which relates to personal information'. A current answer must not reproduce the former clause as operative law. Equally, it should not claim that all balancing vanished: Section 8(2)'s public-interest override, Section 10 severability, Section 11 third-party procedure and appeal remain in the Act. How these provisions interact with the substituted clause may require authoritative adjudication; Section 8(2) should not be treated as automatically restoring every deleted phrase.

Administrators should ask: whose privacy is affected, what public function or expenditure is under scrutiny, what concrete harm follows, and can masking or aggregation serve accountability? Aggregate beneficiary delivery, tender evaluation and conflict information may often be disclosed without unrelated medical, family or identity details. Notice, reasoned redaction and appeal protect both sides.

As of 29 August 2026, the DPDP Act is not wholly operational: Section 44(3) is in force; Section 6(9) and Section 27(1)(d) commence on 13 November 2026; and many core processing, rights and penalty provisions commence on 13 May 2027. Ethical minimisation, security and purpose limitation remain prudent before full commencement. The correct approach is accountable privacy: disclose what tests public power, protect what needlessly exposes the person, and explain the legal balance.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 6 - 20 marks

Question: A State plans to link welfare, health and land databases to detect fraud and publish a district dashboard. As the responsible secretary, design an ethical information-sharing and transparency framework. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

The proposal can detect duplicate claims and improve planning, but it combines distinct purposes and creates exclusion, profiling, breach and function-creep risks. Stakeholders include genuine beneficiaries, wrongly flagged families, officials, local bodies, data processors, auditors and the public. I would not authorise unrestricted linkage or publication.

First, each exchange must identify legal authority, a specific fraud or planning purpose, necessary fields, data quality and a responsible officer. A documented sharing agreement should prohibit unrelated reuse, set role-based access, encryption, retention and deletion, preserve logs, require breach response and permit independent audit. High-risk matches should be treated as leads, never automatic grounds for benefit denial. Affected persons need notice where lawful, assisted correction, a speaking decision and prompt human appeal.

Second, the public dashboard should use aggregation and suppression thresholds so citizens can compare allocation, delivery, pendency and grievance outcomes without exposing names, diagnoses or precise land identifiers. Methodology, update date, limitations and responsible office should be published. File-level records remain available through RTI subject to exemptions, severability and third-party procedure.

Third, an oversight group including legal, security, programme and field expertise should test bias, false matches and access patterns. Periodic necessity review must terminate fields or linkages that do not improve the stated purpose. Procurement contracts should ensure portability and government audit access.

Puttaswamy supplies the legality and proportionality discipline; data ethics adds minimisation and purpose limitation. The framework therefore separates restricted sharing from public disclosure, and connects both to answerability, correction and remedy. Fraud control is legitimate only when the information system does not make an innocent citizen transparent to an unaccountable State.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Subject: Ethics | **Tier:** Optional Advanced Depth | **GS Paper:** GS-IV This companion deepens the corrected Basic owner. It does not replace the Basic statutory route. **FACT:** = sourced fact | **ANALYSIS:** = analysis/inference | **CURRENT:** = current anchor.

1. Transparency as an information architecture of power

ANALYSIS: Transparency is often described as “sunlight,” but the metaphor can hide four distinct design questions:

1. **What becomes visible?** Rules, inputs, reasons, decisions, expenditure, implementation and outcomes.
2. **To whom?** The public, an affected person, an auditor, a legislature or a security-cleared reviewer.
3. **In what form?** Raw data, certified record, speaking order, aggregate dashboard or redacted file.
4. **With what consequence?** Understanding, participation, appeal, audit, correction or sanction.

VISIBILITY WITHOUT STRUCTURE

large data dump
no metadata
no responsible actor
no correction route

|
v

informational noise

ACCOUNTABLE TRANSPARENCY

reliable record
+ intelligible reason
+ named owner
+ competent review

|
v

contestable public power

ANALYSIS: **Epistemic transparency** lets a person know the basis of action. **Procedural transparency** shows how a decision was reached. **Fiscal transparency** tracks public money. **Outcome transparency** shows what changed. They can diverge: a scheme may publish expenditure but conceal selection reasons; a department may explain procedure without publishing outcome failures.

ANALYSIS: Transparency also has distributive effects. Legally literate groups can exploit complex portals more easily than marginal citizens. Equal formal access therefore needs assistance, language, disability access, low cost and usable records.

2. From proactive disclosure to information stewardship

FACT: Section 4 links access with record organisation. Advanced analysis should treat record management as an ethical precondition, not back-office housekeeping.

Stewardship failure	Transparency consequence	Institutional response
No retention schedule	Requested evidence disappears or cannot be trusted.	Lawful retention, disposal authorisation and audit.
Missing metadata	Search retrieves incomplete or contextless material.	Standard names, dates, version and provenance.
Scanned image-only files	Nominal publication remains difficult to search or analyse.	OCR/searchable and accessible formats where feasible.
Vendor lock-in	Public records become dependent on proprietary systems.	Portability, export rights, open standards and exit clauses.
Silent correction	Earlier public version cannot be reconstructed.	Version history and correction log.
Excessive collection	More disclosure/breach risk without public value.	Purpose and data minimisation.

ANALYSIS: **Open by design** should mean:

- identify likely recurring information demands when a programme is created;
- structure records to answer them;
- publish non-sensitive core fields and reasons;
- protect personal/security layers through access control and redaction;
- preserve file-level RTI and appeal for information not suited to public release.

ANALYSIS: Proactive disclosure can reduce backlog, but it can also shift cost to citizens if departments publish unusable material and then direct every applicant to a portal. A defensible Section 4 system has a human assistance route and a correction mechanism.

3. Exemption reasoning: class, harm, balance and narrowness

Advanced answers should separate four questions:

- (1) **COVERAGE:** Does a Section 8 clause apply?
|
(2) **HARM:** What protected interest is likely to be injured?
|
(3) **OVERRIDE:** Does Section 8(2) public interest outweigh that harm?
|
(4) **NARROWNESS:** Can Section 10 redaction or aggregation protect both sides?

ANALYSIS: A clause can be applicable without requiring maximal withholding. Conversely, strong public interest does not erase the need to identify foreseeable harm.

High-yield boundaries

- **Investigation:** the question is whether disclosure would impede investigation/apprehension/prosecution, not merely whether a file is connected with a pending inquiry.
- **Fiduciary:** official custody is not automatically fiduciary. Identify reliance, confidence and the role in which information was entrusted.
- **Commercial confidence:** distinguish genuine competitive technique or trade secret from basic public-contract value, evaluation norms and post-award accountability.
- **Cabinet material:** distinguish protected deliberative material from decisions, reasons and material whose statutory release conditions have matured.
- **Safety/source:** disclosure design should protect identities where the accountability purpose can be served through redaction.

ANALYSIS: Public-interest factors may include evidence of corruption, rights violation, environmental or health risk, misuse of public money, conflict of interest and systemic discrimination. Curiosity, private rivalry or sensational value is weak. The authority should not use “public interest” as an unreasoned conclusion on either side.

4. Severability, mosaic risk and calibrated access

FACT: Section 10 assumes that the record can sometimes be divided into exempt and non-exempt parts. Digital systems make field-level redaction easier, but also create **mosaic risk**: individually safe fields may identify a person or reveal a sensitive pattern when combined.

ANALYSIS: A calibrated decision can use:

- removal of names, phone numbers, exact addresses or protected coordinates;
- aggregation by ward, district or category;
- suppression of small cells;
- delayed publication where timing creates operational harm;
- restricted access to an auditor or affected person rather than the whole public;
- explanatory summaries alongside the underlying non-exempt record.

Example: publishing a village-level list may be necessary to verify a works programme, while health status, bank details and unrelated family information remain masked. If names are indispensable to detect ghost beneficiaries, the authority must explain that public purpose and use the least intrusive fields.

ANALYSIS: Severability is not falsification. Redaction should be marked and explained sufficiently to permit appeal; a document altered without indicating omission undermines trust.

5. Third-party procedure and multi-party fairness

FACT: Section 11 protects procedural fairness when disclosure may affect a third party. Advanced analysis distinguishes:

Actor	Legitimate interest
Applicant	Timely access, reasons and appeal.
Third party	Notice, representation, protection of lawful confidence and appeal.
PIO	Independent statutory decision, not mechanical acceptance of either side.
Public	Integrity of expenditure, regulation and public decision-making.

ANALYSIS: Third-party status is not equivalent to private ownership of an official record. A contractor cannot convert a completed public contract into a private file; equally, the State should not expose a proprietary formula merely because the contractor dealt with government.

Decision method: identify confidential component -> issue timely notice -> test evidence of harm -> assess public interest -> sever where feasible -> give a speaking decision to the relevant parties -> preserve appeal.

ANALYSIS: Delay can itself defeat fairness where commercial or personal harm is immediate. Section 11's special timeline should not become an excuse for indefinite consultation.

6. Enforcement quality and institutional independence

RTI's formal right depends on a functioning chain:

reliable records -> trained PIO -> independent first appeal -> accessible Commission
-> reasoned order -> compliance -> penalty where statutory -> systemic learning

ANALYSIS: Common design risks include:

- vacancies and inadequate benches;
- weak record systems that make orders difficult to execute;
- first appeals treated as internal formality;
- inconsistent penalty reasoning;
- non-compliance without tracking;
- excessive focus on disposal numbers instead of quality and effect;
- intimidation or high transaction cost for applicants.

2019 Amendment: precise institutional reading

FACT: The Amendment transferred tenure and remuneration detail from the Act to Central Government rule-making for both Central and State Information Commissions. FACT: The three-year term is in the 2019 Rules, not in the Amendment's words.

ANALYSIS: The constitutional-ethics concern is **structural dependence**: an adjudicator should have security sufficient to decide claims against government without reasonable fear of executive leverage. Statutory entrenchment is generally more durable than an amendable executive rule.

Counterpoints and qualifications:

- uniform service conditions may aid administration;
- no tenure design guarantees good adjudication;
- statutory fixation alone cannot cure vacancies, weak staff or poor orders;
- the Amendment's existence does not prove that a commissioner was influenced;
- the citizen's Section 3 right and Sections 19-20 architecture remain.

ANALYSIS: Reform should combine statutory core safeguards, transparent and timely appointment, published selection criteria, adequate resources, reasoned orders, compliance monitoring and protection from outcome-based performance pressure.

7. Official Secrets Act: conflict of norms and administrative culture

FACT: The OSA remains law. FACT: Section 22 gives RTI priority to the extent of inconsistency. FACT: The Second ARC recommended repeal of OSA and relocation of genuine secrecy offences; the recommendation was not enacted.

The deeper issue is a conflict of administrative defaults:

SECRECY CULTURE

classification by habit
need-to-know citizen
fear of all disclosure
whole-file denial
no expiry review

RTI CULTURE

clause-linked withholding
citizen need not give reasons
distinguish genuine harm
sever protected portions
periodic review and appeal

ANALYSIS: A modern secrecy system should classify narrowly, identify the authority and reason, review classification, permit independent scrutiny and protect genuine operational information. RTI is not a substitute for a coherent classification law, but OSA should not be used to bypass RTI's tests.

2019 PYQ thesis: OSA can obstruct RTI through broad wording and secrecy culture; legally, Section 22 prevents it from being an automatic trump card. The solution is not reckless disclosure but harm-based classification, RTI adjudication, severability and review.

8. Privacy after Puttaswamy and the changed Section 8(1)(j)

FACT: *Puttaswamy* recognises privacy as fundamental and connects it with dignity, autonomy and the freedoms in Part III. For State information systems, use:

1. legality;
2. legitimate State aim;
3. rational connection and proportionality/necessity;
4. procedural safeguards, oversight and remedy.

ANALYSIS: Privacy is contextual. The same field may be appropriate for a treating doctor, necessary for a restricted benefits administrator, unnecessary for an unrelated department and harmful on a public dashboard.

CURRENT: Statutory change effective 13 November 2025

FACT: DPDP Section 44(3) substituted RTI Section 8(1)(j) with “**information which relates to personal information**”. G.S.R. 843(E) commenced that subsection immediately on publication.

The analytical consequence is significant:

- the former clause-specific public-activity/unwarranted-invasion/larger-public-interest language is no longer in clause (j);
- Section 8(2)'s general public-interest override remains;
- Section 10 severability and Section 11 third-party procedure remain;
- appeals remain available;
- courts/Commissions may need to clarify interaction and scope.

ANALYSIS: Avoid two opposite overstatements:

1. “**Privacy now defeats every RTI request involving a person.**” This ignores the rest of the Act, the meaning and application of the substituted clause, severability and statutory review.
2. “**Nothing changed because Section 8(2) automatically restores the old test.**” This understates Parliament's textual substitution and assumes an adjudicatory conclusion.

Commencement discipline

CURRENT: At 29 August 2026, the DPDP framework is phased. Section 44(3) is operative. The one-year tranche containing Section 6(9) and Section 27(1)(d) commences 13 November 2026. Sections 3-5, the rest of Section 6, Sections 7-17 and linked core architecture belong to the eighteen-month tranche commencing 13 May 2027. Do not say “the entire DPDP Act came into force in November 2025.”

ANALYSIS: Ethical data stewardship is not postponed: administrators should already minimise collection, restrict reuse, secure data, maintain accuracy and provide correction.

9. Information sharing, interoperability and open-government limits

Digital government creates pressure to “join up” records. Interoperability can reduce repeated documents, detect duplicate payments and improve policy evidence, but it can also create a surveillance architecture by accretion.

Advanced purpose-bound sharing test

AUTHORITY -> PURPOSE -> NECESSITY -> DATA QUALITY -> ACCESS -> RETENTION
-> SECURITY -> HUMAN REVIEW -> CORRECTION -> AUDIT -> SUNSET/REAUTHORISE

- **Authority:** identify statute, rule, order or valid administrative competence.
- **Purpose:** prohibit vague “future use.”
- **Necessity:** field-by-field justification, not whole-database convenience.
- **Accuracy:** a wrong match should not propagate across departments.
- **Access:** least privilege and tamper-evident logs.
- **Retention:** sharing should not create immortal shadow copies.
- **Human review:** matches are evidence leads, not automatic adverse decisions.
- **Correction:** repair the source and downstream copies.
- **Audit/sunset:** measure benefits, exclusions, breaches and continued need.

ANALYSIS: **Transparency paradox:** making citizens maximally legible to government can increase State power while the algorithm, data linkage and responsible officials remain opaque. Ethical digital government reverses the asymmetry: public power and system rules should be visible, while citizen data remain purpose-limited.

ANALYSIS: Open-data policy should assess re-identification, group harm and mosaic risk. “Anonymised” is a claim requiring testing, not a magic label.

10. Advanced answer synthesis, reforms and source boundaries

Reform matrix

Problem	Reform	Qualification
Repetitive RTI requests	Audited Section 4 disclosure with search, metadata and updates.	Preserve individual access for file-specific needs.
Weak record systems	Retention, provenance, versioning, portability and lawful disposal.	Avoid collecting data without purpose.
Generic exemption orders	Clause-harm-public-interest-severability template plus training.	Templates must not replace individual reasons.
First-appeal formality	Independent senior review, speaking orders and compliance tracking.	Preserve speed and avoid needless procedural layers.
Commission dependence/vacancy	Statutory core safeguards, timely transparent appointment and resources.	Do not infer actual bias from design concern alone.
Privacy overexposure	Aggregation, masking, access tiers, Section 10 and purpose limitation.	Do not hide public-power evidence by over-redaction.
Unsafe data sharing	Sharing agreements, minimum fields, logs, correction, audit and sunset.	Urgent lawful sharing can remain possible with later review.

PYQ-ready theses

- **2018 RTI/accountability:** RTI changes the burden of justification and creates a documented appeal-and-penalty route, but disclosed facts need a corrective forum.
- **2019 OSA/RTI:** OSA is an obstacle as culture and possible overbreadth; Section 22 prevents a blanket legal trump, while Sections 8, 8(2) and 10 protect legitimate secrecy proportionately.

- **Privacy question:** accountable privacy protects personal dignity while disclosing the exercise of public power; use the current Section 8(1)(j) text and phased DPDP date.

- **Digital sharing question:** distinguish restricted purpose-bound exchange from public transparency; publish safe aggregates and system rules while preserving correction and appeal.

Source and ownership cautions

- Official local GS-IV PDFs control exact question text. Routing ledgers establish ownership, not permission to invent or merge demands.
- Full case-study method remains Topic 22-owned.
- ARC recommendations are reform evidence, not enacted law.
- Puttaswamy is the privacy foundation; do not reduce its constitutional reasoning to consent alone.
- The DoPT 2025-26 RTI propagation programme evidences current implementation effort, not universal Section 4 compliance.
- G.S.R. 843(E) proves phased commencement and immediate operation of Section 44(3); it does not prove the whole DPDP framework was operational in November 2025.

Qualified conclusion

ANALYSIS: The ethical objective is neither a glass citizen before an opaque State nor an unreviewable State hidden behind privacy and security. It is **asymmetric transparency in favour of constitutional accountability**: make public power, criteria, expenditure and reasons visible; protect personal and operational information only through lawful, narrow and reasoned measures; and preserve an effective route to correction.

Official current-source note

- DoPT, RTI propagation annual programme, 2025-26:

https://rti.dopt.gov.in/Writereaddata/Guidelines_2025_26.pdf

- MeitY, G.S.R. 843(E), 13 November 2025:

<https://www.meity.gov.in/static/uploads/2025/11/c56ceae6c383460ca69577428d36828b.pdf>

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

EMBEDDED TWELVE-PANEL ASCII REVISION ATLAS

The panels compress the learning route without replacing the complete teaching and solved practice above.

ASCII PANEL 1/12 - 1. Information-governance distinction map

CENTRAL FOCUS

1. Information-governance distinction map

- [1] Transparency: systemic visibility
 - |
 - v
- [2] Disclosure: particular release
 - |
 - v
- [3] Sharing: purpose-bound exchange
 - |
 - v
- [4] Open data: reusable datasets
 - |
 - v
- [5] Privacy: dignity and control
 - |
 - v
- [6] Accountability: answerability
 - |
 - v
- [7] Forum supplies correction
 - |
 - v
- [8] Law sets legitimate limits
 - |
 - v

VERDICT -> Moving information is not identical to making power accountable.

ANSWER USE -> Use to define the topic and prevent synonym traps.

ASCII PANEL 2/12 - 2. RTI scope and rights-holder route

CENTRAL FOCUS

2. RTI scope and rights-holder route

- [1] Section 3: citizen's right
 - |
 - v
- [2] Identify public authority
 - |
 - v
- [3] Locate held or controlled record
 - |
 - v
- [4] Include law-accessible private data
 - |
 - v
- [5] Do not demand new opinion
 - |
 - v
- [6] Applicant need not give reasons
 - |
 - v
- [7] Assist persons needing help
 - |
 - v
- [8] Apply exemptions only afterward
 - |
 - v

VERDICT -> RTI opens existing recorded information; it does not compel fresh intellectual creation.

ANSWER USE -> Use for Sections 2, 3 and 6 answers.

ASCII PANEL 3/12 - 3. Section 4 proactive-disclosure engine

CENTRAL FOCUS

3. Section 4 proactive-disclosure engine

- [1] Catalogue and index records
 - |
 - v
- [2] Computerise appropriate records
 - |
 - v
- [3] Publish organisation and duties
 - |
 - v
- [4] Publish norms and decision process
 - |
 - v
- [5] Publish budget and programmes
 - |
 - v
- [6] Publish subsidies and concessions
 - |
 - v
- [7] Update, search and make accessible
 - |
 - v
- [8] Minimise need for applications
 - |
 - v

VERDICT -> The strongest RTI system answers routine questions before they become disputes.

ANSWER USE -> Use for reform, capacity and anti-corruption answers.

ASCII PANEL 4/12 - 4. Sections 6 and 7 request clock

CENTRAL FOCUS

4. Sections 6 and 7 request clock

- [1] File written or electronic request
 - |
 - v
- [2] Use English, Hindi or local official language
 - |
 - v
- [3] Give contact detail, not reasons
 - |
 - v
- [4] Transfer under Section 6(3)
 - |
 - v
- [5] Ordinary decision: thirty days
 - |
 - v
- [6] Life or liberty: forty-eight hours
 - |
 - v
- [7] Silence becomes deemed refusal
 - |
 - v
- [8] Delay makes information free
 - |
 - v

VERDICT -> Access is meaningful only when procedure is simple, assisted and time-bound.

ANSWER USE -> Use for application and timeline close-option questions.

ASCII PANEL 5/12 - 5. Section 8 exemption and balance

CENTRAL FOCUS

5. Section 8 exemption and balance

- [1] Name exact exemption clause
|
v
- [2] Identify protected interest
|
v
- [3] Specify likely disclosure harm
|
v
- [4] Reject generic confidentiality
|
v
- [5] Test Section 8(2) public interest
|
v
- [6] Consider twenty-year rule
|
v
- [7] Record clause-linked reasons
|
v
- [8] Preserve appeal and review
|
v

VERDICT -> A protected interest requires a reasoned harm analysis, not a secrecy label.

ANSWER USE -> Use for exemptions, OSA and public-interest questions.

ASCII PANEL 6/12 - 6. Severability and third-party procedure

CENTRAL FOCUS

6. Severability and third-party procedure

- [1] Identify protected segment
|
v
- [2] Test reasonable separation
|
v
- [3] Release non-exempt remainder
|
v
- [4] Notify reasons and review rights
|
v
- [5] Notify affected third party
|
v
- [6] Receive timely representation
|
v
- [7] PIO decides independently
|
v
- [8] Notify both sides of appeal
|
v

VERDICT -> Redaction narrows secrecy; consultation improves fairness without creating a veto.

ANSWER USE -> Use for Sections 10 and 11.

ASCII PANEL 7/12 - 7. Appeal, burden, remedy and penalty

CENTRAL FOCUS

7. Appeal, burden, remedy and penalty

- [1] PIO gives decision or defaults
 - |
 - v
- [2] First appeal within authority
 - |
 - v
- [3] Second appeal to Commission
 - |
 - v
- [4] PIO bears denial burden
 - |
 - v
- [5] Commission may order access
 - |
 - v
- [6] Commission may require system reform
 - |
 - v
- [7] Section 20 penalty is conditional
 - |
 - v
- [8] Persistent default may trigger discipline
 - |
 - v

VERDICT -> RTI accountability joins access, justification, correction and personal consequence.

ANSWER USE -> Use for 2018 Q2(b) and enforcement reform.

ASCII PANEL 8/12 - 8. Section 24 special boundary

CENTRAL FOCUS

8. Section 24 special boundary

- [1] Check notified security organisation
 - |
 - v
- [2] General exclusion applies
 - |
 - v
- [3] Test corruption allegation
 - |
 - v
- [4] Test human-rights allegation
 - |
 - v
- [5] Corruption route remains open
 - |
 - v
- [6] Human-rights route needs approval
 - |
 - v
- [7] Apply special forty-five-day period
 - |
 - v
- [8] Protect genuine operational harm
 - |
 - v

VERDICT -> Security-organisation exclusion is broad but not absolute.

ANSWER USE -> Use for statutory traps and balanced national-security answers.

ASCII PANEL 9/12 - 9. RTI Amendment 2019 institutional map

CENTRAL FOCUS

9. RTI Amendment 2019 institutional map

- [1] Pre-2019 tenure fixed in Act
 - ↓
- [2] Pre-2019 salary links fixed in Act
 - ↓
- [3] 2019 shifts detail to Central rules
 - ↓
- [4] Change covers Central Commissions
 - ↓
- [5] Change also covers State Commissions
 - ↓
- [6] Rules prescribe three-year term
 - ↓
- [7] Independence concern is structural
 - ↓
- [8] Actual interference is not proved
 - ↓

VERDICT -> State the design risk precisely without claiming that RTI rights were abolished.

ANSWER USE -> Use for institutional-independence evaluation.

ASCII PANEL 10/12 - 10. OSA and RTI interface

CENTRAL FOCUS

10. OSA and RTI interface

- [1] OSA 1923 remains in force
 - ↓
- [2] ARC recommended repeal and relocation
 - ↓
- [3] Recommendation is not enacted law
 - ↓
- [4] RTI Section 22 overrides inconsistency
 - ↓
- [5] Section 8 protects genuine interests
 - ↓
- [6] Section 8(2) weighs public interest
 - ↓
- [7] Section 10 narrows withholding
 - ↓
- [8] Reasoned review replaces blanket label
 - ↓

VERDICT -> Official secrecy survives, but it cannot bypass the RTI Act's own decision architecture.

ANSWER USE -> Use for the 2019 direct PYQ.

ASCII PANEL 11/12 - 11. Privacy after Puttaswamy and DPDP

CENTRAL FOCUS

11. Privacy after Puttaswamy and DPDP

- [1] Privacy protects dignity and autonomy
 - |
 - v
- [2] State action needs legality
 - |
 - v
- [3] Aim and proportionality matter
 - |
 - v
- [4] Safeguards and remedy matter
 - |
 - v
- [5] Section 44(3) commenced 13 Nov 2025
 - |
 - v
- [6] RTI 8(1)(j) text was substituted
 - |
 - v
- [7] Sections 8(2), 10 and 11 remain
 - |
 - v
- [8] Sec 6(9): 13 Nov 2026; core: 13 May 2027
 - |
 - v

VERDICT -> Use current text and acknowledge unresolved interaction instead of reviving deleted wording.

ANSWER USE -> Use for privacy-transparency and current-law answers.

ASCII PANEL 12/12 - 12. Ethical digital information-sharing design

CENTRAL FOCUS

12. Ethical digital information-sharing design

- [1] Establish lawful authority
 - |
 - v
- [2] Define specific purpose
 - |
 - v
- [3] Share minimum necessary fields
 - |
 - v
- [4] Verify accuracy and provenance
 - |
 - v
- [5] Control access and retention
 - |
 - v
- [6] Publish only safe aggregates
 - |
 - v
- [7] Enable correction and appeal
 - |
 - v
- [8] Audit necessity, use and outcomes
 - |
 - v

VERDICT -> An accountable State should be transparent about power without making citizens needlessly transparent.

ANSWER USE -> Use for databases, open data and twenty-mark design questions.

ONE-PAGE CONCEPT GRID

Concept / thinker	Exam-ready formulation
Transparency is a systemic condition, not one isolated release	Transparency is the continuing institutional visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and results to appropriate scrutiny; one compelled disclosure may reveal information without changing an organisation's secrecy-oriented default.
Disclosure is a particular act of making information available	Disclosure is the release of specified information to a person or public, whether proactively or on request; it is an instrument of transparency but does not by itself create answerability, correction or consequence.
Information sharing is purpose-bound exchange, not automatic publication	Information sharing is the authorised movement of information between officials, institutions or persons for a defined function; unlike public disclosure, it may remain restricted and must respect necessity, accuracy, security and privacy.
Accountability requires answerability and a corrective forum	Accountability exists when an identified actor must explain conduct against a standard before a competent forum capable of judgment, correction, remedy or consequence; visibility is enabling evidence, not the completed relationship.
Section 3 creates a citizen's statutory right	The Right to Information Act confers the right to information on all citizens; applicants ordinarily need not establish a special interest, although access remains subject to the Act's defined scope and exemptions.
RTI reaches existing material held or controlled, not new explanations	The Act concerns information in material form held by or under the control of a public authority, including accessible private-body material under another law; it does not generally require creation of fresh opinions, analysis or answers.
Section 6 minimises applicant burden and requires transfer	A request may be made in writing or electronically in English, Hindi or the area's official language; reasons cannot be demanded, assistance is due where needed, and a misdirected request must be transferred promptly.
Section 7 combines ordinary, urgent and deemed-refusal timelines	The ordinary RTI decision period is thirty days, life-or-liberty information is due within forty-eight hours, silence becomes deemed refusal, and information is free when the authority misses the statutory time limit.
Section 4 makes proactive disclosure the first transparency channel	RTI requires organised records and specified suo motu publication, with a constant endeavour to provide information proactively so citizens need minimum resort to individual requests.
Usability matters alongside publication	Proactive transparency requires current, searchable, accessible and intelligible information, not merely scanned dumps or obsolete links; publication without findability, context, disability access or timely updating can become compliance theatre.
Open data and RTI overlap but are not identical	Open data emphasises reusable, often machine-readable public datasets, whereas RTI can also secure records, reasons and correspondence not suitable for open release; both remain bounded by lawful confidentiality, security and privacy.
Digital records can reduce opacity but preserve new risks	Digitisation can improve search, time stamps, audit trails and simultaneous access, yet poor indexing context, deletion, vendor lock-in, manipulated logs, cyber insecurity and inaccessible interfaces can reproduce opacity electronically.

CORE REVISION SPINE

- **Section 8 exemptions are specific protections, not a secrecy slogan:** RTI exemptions protect defined interests such as security, judicial restrictions, legislative privilege, commercial confidence, fiduciary information, safety, investigation, cabinet material and personal information; withholding needs clause-linked reasoning.
- **Section 8(2) retains a statutory public-interest override:** The statutory public-interest override permits access despite official-secrecy law or listed exemptions where disclosure benefit outweighs harm to protected interests; it requires a reasoned balance, not an automatic presumption.
- **Section 10 requires severability:** Where an exempt part can reasonably be separated from the remainder, severability requires access to the non-exempt record with notice of reasons, decision-maker, fee and review rights rather than blanket withholding.
- **Section 11 is consultation, not a third-party veto:** Confidential third-party material triggers notice and consideration, but the PIO makes the reasoned decision subject to public-interest and appeal rules; the third party does not possess an absolute veto.
- **Section 19 makes the PIO justify denial:** RTI provides a first appeal within the public authority and a second appeal to the Information Commission; in appeal proceedings the burden of proving that denial was justified lies on the denying PIO.
- **Section 20 penalty is personal, conditional and capped:** The Information Commission may impose two hundred and fifty rupees per day up to twenty-five thousand rupees for specified PIO failures after hearing, unless reasonable and diligent conduct is proved; persistent default may support disciplinary recommendation.
- **Section 24 exclusion has corruption and human-rights exceptions:** Specified intelligence and security organisations are generally excluded, but information concerning allegations of corruption or human-rights violations is not wholly outside the Act; human-rights disclosure follows Commission approval and a special timeline.
- **The 2019 amendment shifted service-condition detail to rules:** The RTI Amendment Act, 2019 replaced Parliament-fixed tenure and salary links for Central and State Information Commissioners with terms prescribed by the Central Government; the 2019 Rules prescribe a three-year term, subject to the age ceiling.
- **Section 22 displaces inconsistent secrecy law without repealing it:** The RTI Act overrides inconsistent provisions, including official-secrecy law, while the OSA remains in force; genuine protected interests must therefore be tested through RTI's exemption architecture.
- **Privacy and transparency protect different democratic goods:** Privacy protects dignity, autonomy and contextual control over personal information, while transparency checks public power and expenditure; a sound decision identifies whose privacy, what public function and whether narrower disclosure can serve the interest.
- **DPDP Section 44(3) changed the text of RTI Section 8(1)(j):** From 13 November 2025, the DPDP amendment substituted the RTI personal-information exemption with 'information which relates to personal information'; public-interest, severability and third-party provisions remain, requiring careful legal reasoning.
- **Purpose limitation governs inter-departmental sharing:** Government possession does not create unlimited permission to circulate data; ethical information sharing should have lawful authority, a defined purpose, minimum necessary fields, accuracy, access control, retention limits, security and an auditable remedy route.

SOURCE AND ATTRIBUTION DISCIPLINE

The corrected canonical Topic 15 Basic and Advanced owners control the teaching sequence. Transparency is systemic visibility; disclosure is a particular release; information sharing is purpose-bound exchange; open data concerns reusable datasets; accountability requires an actor, standard, competent forum, judgment and correction or consequence; privacy protects dignity, autonomy and contextual control. Do not use these terms as synonyms. RTI covers existing information held or controlled by a public authority, including private-body information accessible under another law; it does not generally compel creation of opinions or analysis. Section 4 proactive disclosure should be current, intelligible and accessible. Section 6 applicants need not give reasons; Section 7 ordinarily uses thirty days and forty-eight hours for life or liberty. Section 8 exemptions require clause-linked reasoning; Section 8(2) retains public-interest balancing; Section 10 requires reasonable severability; Section 11 consultation is not a third-party veto. Section 19 places the denial burden on the PIO. Section 20 penalty is personal, hearing-based, conditional on specified failure and capped at twenty-five thousand rupees; it is not an automatic departmental fine. Section 24

exclusions retain corruption and human-rights exceptions, with Commission approval and a forty-five-day rule for the latter. The Official Secrets Act, 1923 remains in force; the Second ARC recommendation to repeal and relocate genuine secrecy offences was not enacted. RTI Section 22 overrides inconsistent law but does not abolish legitimate RTI exemptions. The RTI Amendment Act, 2019 shifted tenure and remuneration detail for Central and State Information Commissioners from the Act to Central rules; the three-year term comes from the 2019 Rules, not the Amendment's text. Describe the resulting independence issue as a structural concern, not proof of actual interference or abolition of the right. Puttaswamy is the constitutional privacy foundation. DPDP Act Section 44(3) commenced on 13 November 2025 and substituted RTI Section 8(1)(j) with 'information which relates to personal information'. Sections 8(2), 10 and 11 remain, but do not claim without authority that Section 8(2) automatically recreates every deleted qualifier. G.S.R. 843(E) phased commencement: as at 29 August 2026 the Act is not wholly operational; Section 6(9) and Section 27(1)(d) commence on 13 November 2026, while the major eighteen-month tranche begins 13 May 2027. Official local GS-IV PDFs control PYQ text. Cross-routed questions retain their primary owners, and full case-study method remains Topic 22-owned.

ANSWER SPINE

1. Define the precise ethical concept or teaching.
2. State a qualified thesis rather than a moral slogan.
3. Explain the causal or decision-making mechanism.
4. Add one specific Indian administrative illustration.
5. Test the strongest limitation or attribution caveat.
6. End with a practical, institution-aware verdict.

TEN-SESSION RAPID REGISTER

1. CONCEPTUAL FIREWALLS

- **Transparency:** continuing visibility of rules, criteria, reasons, records and outcomes to appropriate scrutiny.
- **Disclosure:** one act of release; proactive or request-based; public or person-specific.
- **Information sharing:** authorised exchange for a defined function; it may remain restricted.
- **Open data:** reusable, usually machine-readable public datasets; it does not replace access to reasons or files.
- **Accountability:** actor + standard + forum + evidence/reasons + judgment + correction/remedy/consequence.
- **Privacy:** dignity, autonomy and contextual control; not identical to secrecy.
- **Master line:** transparency enables accountability but does not complete it.

2. RTI SCOPE AND RIGHTS-HOLDER

- **Section 3:** right belongs to citizens; a special personal interest is ordinarily unnecessary.
- **Information:** existing material in any form held or controlled; includes private-body material accessible by a public authority under another law.
- **Right to information:** inspection, notes/extracts, certified copies, certified samples and electronic access as statutorily described.
- **Boundary:** PIO supplies records, not a newly invented opinion, justification or research product.
- **Public authority:** use the statutory control, constitution, law, notification and substantial-financing tests; do not assume every private entity is directly covered.

3. SECTION 4: DISCLOSE BEFORE DEMAND

- Catalogue, index and appropriately computerise records; connect systems where access is facilitated.
- Publish organisation, powers, duties, decision process, norms, rules, document categories, consultation arrangements, boards, directory, remuneration, budget, subsidy programmes, concessions and PIO particulars under the statutory clauses.
- Update disclosures; use local language, accessible formats, search, metadata and low-cost dissemination.
- **Section 4(2):** constant endeavour to provide as much information suo motu at regular intervals so the public has minimum resort to RTI applications.

- **Trap:** upload is not usability. Scanned, obsolete or unsearchable material can be compliance theatre.

4. REQUEST AND TIME ROUTE

- **Section 6:** written/electronic request in English, Hindi or official language of the area; no reasons; reasonable assistance where required.
- **Section 6(3):** transfer to the appropriate public authority as soon as practicable and within five days, with applicant informed.
- **Section 7:** ordinary decision within thirty days; life or liberty within forty-eight hours; silence is deemed refusal.
- BPL applicants are protected by the statutory fee rule; delayed information is supplied free under Section 7(6).
- Assist persons with sensory disability to access the record.

5. EXEMPTION AND PUBLIC-INTEREST BALANCE

- **Section 8(1):** identify the exact clause and protected interest; 'secret', 'confidential' or 'sensitive' alone is not analysis.
- Common heads: sovereignty/security; court-forbidden information; legislative privilege; commercial confidence/IP; fiduciary material; foreign-government confidence; safety/source; investigation; cabinet material; personal information.
- **Section 8(2):** disclosure may proceed where public interest outweighs harm to protected interests, notwithstanding OSA or Section 8(1).
- **Section 8(3):** after twenty years, disclosure rule applies subject to the continuing statutory exceptions; do not state an absolute twenty-year declassification rule.
- Use a four-step balance: clause -> concrete harm -> public benefit -> narrower alternative/reasons.

6. SEVERABILITY AND THIRD PARTY

- **Section 10:** separate protected and non-protected portions where reasonable; release remainder and notify reasons, decision-maker, fee and review rights.
- **Section 11:** notice to affected third party, opportunity to represent, independent PIO decision and appeal notice.
- **Timing recall:** notice within five days; representation opportunity within ten days; decision ordinarily within forty days for the third-party route.
- **Trap:** consultation is not consent and not veto. The statutory decision remains with the PIO/appellate system.

7. APPEAL, REMEDY, PENALTY AND SECTION 24

- **Section 19:** first appeal within the public authority; second appeal to CIC/SIC; ordinarily thirty and ninety days respectively, subject to sufficient-cause admission.
- First appeal ordinarily decided within thirty days, extendable to forty-five days with written reasons.
- **Section 19(5):** PIO bears burden of proving denial justified.
- **Section 20:** Rs 250 per day, maximum Rs 25,000, after opportunity of hearing, for specified failures; reasonable diligence is relevant; persistent default may support disciplinary recommendation.
- **Section 24:** listed security/intelligence organisations generally excluded, but corruption and human-rights allegations remain exceptions; human-rights information needs Commission approval and follows forty-five days.

8. INFORMATION COMMISSION INDEPENDENCE

- Pre-2019 core tenure and salary links were fixed in the Act; the 2019 Amendment shifted tenure, salary, allowances and service conditions to Central Government rules for Central and State commissioners.
- The **three-year** term is prescribed by the RTI Rules, 2019, subject to age sixty-five; do not attribute that number to the Amendment Act itself.
- Ethics issue: adjudicator insulation, security of tenure, federal design and appearance of independence.
- Qualification: the amendment did not repeal Section 3, appeal or penalty, and does not prove interference in a decided case.
- Reform bundle: statutory safeguards + timely transparent appointments + adequate staffing + reasoned decisions + publication of performance without outcome pressure.

9. OSA, PRIVACY AND CURRENT DPDP POSITION

- OSA 1923 remains in force. Second ARC recommended repeal and relocation of genuine secrecy provisions; recommendation is not law.
- **Section 22:** RTI prevails to the extent of inconsistency; test secrecy through Sections 8, 10 and appeal.
- **Puttaswamy (2017):** privacy is fundamental; State restriction requires legality, legitimate aim, proportionality and safeguards.
- **13 Nov 2025:** DPDP Section 44(3) commenced and RTI Section 8(1)(j) became 'information which relates to personal information'.
- Sections 8(2), 10 and 11 survive. Their interaction with the substituted clause must be argued carefully, not assumed away.
- **29 Aug 2026 status:** DPDP is not wholly operational; Section 6(9) and Section 27(1)(d) commence 13 Nov 2026; Sections 3-5, the rest of Section 6, Sections 7-17 and linked core architecture commence 13 May 2027.

10. DIGITAL SHARING, PYQS AND ANSWER METHOD

- Digital gains: search, time stamp, provenance, simultaneous access, audit trail and machine readability.
- Digital risks: bad metadata, silent deletion, manipulated logs, cyber breach, vendor lock-in, inaccessible portals and false confidence in dashboards.
- Sharing checklist: authority -> purpose -> minimum fields -> accuracy -> access control -> retention -> security -> audit -> correction/remedy.
- Dashboard rule: publish safe aggregates, methodology, limitations, update date and responsible office; never expose personal detail merely to look transparent.
- **Direct PYQs:** 2018 RTI-accountability; 2019 OSA obstacle. **Cross-routes:** public interest, Snowden, institutional ethics, social audit, ethics code and fund accountability.

UPSC TRAP BANK

- RTI is not absolute access, and privacy is not absolute secrecy.
- Section 11 gives consultation, not a third-party veto.
- Section 20 is not an automatic departmental fine for every delay.
- Section 24 exclusion is not absolute because corruption and human-rights routes survive.
- OSA has not been repealed; Section 22 supplies an inconsistency override.
- The 2019 Amendment did not itself prescribe three years and did not abolish the citizen's right.
- The former wording of Section 8(1)(j) is not current after 13 November 2025.
- DPDP is enacted and partly commenced, not wholly operational as at 29 August 2026.
- Open data does not replace recorded reasons, file access or appeal.
- Maximum disclosure is not maximum ethics; use lawful, severable and proportionate openness.

MARK-SCALED ANSWER ARCHITECTURE

1. **Define and distinguish** the nearest concepts in two lines.
2. **State the legal spine** with only demand-relevant sections.
3. **Explain the mechanism:** information asymmetry -> visibility -> verification -> answerability -> correction.
4. **Apply one Indian example:** muster roll, tender, beneficiary dashboard, land record or public expenditure.
5. **Balance the strongest limit:** privacy, security, commercial confidence, capacity or digital exclusion.
6. **Give an operational reform:** proactive disclosure, severability, speaking order, appeal, audit, data minimisation or Commission independence.
7. **Conclude:** transparent public power, protected personal dignity and a competent remedy must coexist.